Becoming Adora

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33503671.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man), Adam (He-Man), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
deadnaming, Misgendering, Suicidal Thoughts, Suicide Attempt, Trauma, Slurs, transphobic slurs, Transphobia, Coming Out, Internalized Transphobia, Internalized Homophobia, Self-Hatred, Divorce, Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - No Powers, Trans Adora (She-Ra), Trans Bow (She-Ra), Trans Female Character, Trans Male Character, /tttt/ Brainworms, Alternate Universe - Middle School, Alternate Universe - High School, Dissociation

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Untitled Trans Adora Series

Stats:
Published: 2021-08-27 Completed: 2021-09-20 Words: 34,338 Chapters: 5/5

Becoming Adora

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33503671.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man), Adam (He-Man), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
deadnaming, Misgendering, Suicidal Thoughts, Suicide Attempt, Trauma, Slurs, transphobic slurs, Transphobia, Coming Out, Internalized Transphobia, Internalized Homophobia, Self-Hatred, Divorce, Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - No Powers, Trans Adora (She-Ra), Trans Bow (She-Ra), Trans Female Character, Trans Male Character, /tttt/ Brainworms, Alternate Universe - Middle School, Alternate Universe - High School, Dissociation

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Untitled Trans Adora Series

Stats:
Published: 2021-08-27 Completed: 2021-09-20 Words: 34,338
Chapters: 5/5

Becoming Adora

by peachpeachpeachpeachpeach

Summary

Coming out is difficult. To yourself, and to everyone else.

It's even more difficult when you finally find the word that describes you perfectly, a word that is the key to figuring out who you are, but it's one that carries a lot of negative implications. A word that means that many people will outright hate you for simply existing and will actively make your life harder. It's a difficult pill to swallow, knowing that your life will be significantly more challenging despite having done nothing wrong, nothing to deserve this. If only it was *something* else, *anything* else…

It's a pill that sometimes seems easier to ignore. To repress, to hide away the shame, to pretend to be the perfect son who got good grades, obeyed his parents, and earned the rank of Eagle Scout, someone to be proud of. Because as horrendous as an experience puberty is, destroying her hopes and dreams in a slow-moving train wreck that showed no signs of stopping, the fear of how others would react seemed far worse.

How long can it last?

Notes

This story is not any one specific person's story, rather it is based on things my friends and I have experienced; it is an amalgamation of our tales with some creative writing mixed in. It is not indicative of anyone else's experiences; being trans is something we all handle differently, from coming out to ourselves, to coming out to others, to transitioning (if we even do any of that).

This story is not focused exclusively on the downsides of being trans (or the "struggle," as some call it), though the first couple chapters may give you that impression. It gets better.

This story is basically the prequel to "Untitled Trans Adora Story" (https://archiveofourown.org/works/32210515). If you haven't read it, you won't be missing out on anything.

CW: read the tags. This contains both some very light and happy moments, but also deals with some very heavy topics.

I listed this under just the SPOP (2018) fandom tag (rather than also including the 1980s She-Ra fandom) because I only use character names from the 1980s She-Ra and He-Man universe (because I'm lazy and didn't feel like coming up with a bunch of character names). Tagging those shows feels inappropriate since I'm not writing towards them.

The Five Stages of Grief

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adrift

I look around,

and I see what it sees.

What even are these things?

Words, I guess, but their meanings

I cannot comprehend.

On the page, a pencil moves

and letters appear.

I know not why the hand moves,

mindlessly transcribing sentences I do not understand

from flashing lights in the distance

for a purpose I cannot comprehend.

I whisper to it "What are you?"

There is no response.

I tell it to blink

but it is all for naught.

Utterly helpless, I suffer in silence.

Everything is running on autopilot –

I know not how it will handle

a disruption, whether peaceful or violent.

I am captain of a ship of insubordination,

commanding a vessel I do not like,

on a course I do not understand,

through treacherous, uncharted waters.

I've been through this before

(it's nothing new),

but it's just as frightening

not being in control.

When will this voyage end?

Laying in her bed the night before Christmas while mindlessly working a Rubik's cube, Aaron felt more adrift than ever before. She knew she was different, but she couldn't figure out how. Of course, middle school is supposed to be awkward, or so she was told, but *this* couldn't be normal. Was she self-conscious? Yes, but she didn't feel like this was a normal level of self-consciousness. To say she had gotten quieter since her body started changing was an understatement. There were days when she spoke less than five sentences to her classmates, occasionally going an entire class without saying a word. Sometimes she felt like she was trapped in a stranger's body, watching someone else do things she

couldn’t follow along with, feeling like her existence was not grounded in reality. Sometimes it lasted only a few moments, other times it was several minutes of feeling like she was nothing but an observer to an alien world, at the mercy of whatever the meatsuit that was her body decided to do.

Her teachers loved her – she was always on task, never missed assignments, never broke the rules; really, she was a model student, and her grades reflected that – but internally, she felt like she was struggling, just barely staying afloat. It didn’t matter that she had worked several months ahead in her online coursework for pre-algebra, what her parents said when she brought home yet another report card filled with A’s, or how her classmates viewed her as some super-genius – she felt she was always on the verge of losing everything, one slip-up away from being put through the wringer.

While some of her classmates (such as her brother) were having rebellious streaks, she was afraid of breaking the rules, of annoying her teachers, of upsetting her parents. Not because they would punish her – she wasn’t afraid of that anymore – but because someone might start to wonder if there was something wrong with her. She *knew* something was deeply wrong, and though she didn’t know what, she could tell that whatever it was wasn’t something she would want anyone to know, or for anyone else to try to figure out.

Since her voice began to drop, she barely sung at church, only doing the bare minimum to keep her parents off her case. During the holidays, singing Christmas carols with her grandparents was a thing of the past. She just didn’t like the way she sounded anymore – she thought she sounded hideous, and that it would be better to keep her volume down than to annoy others with the

horrendous noises that came out of her mouth. It was a perfectly logical reaction, in her mind. Why some of the guys in her classes tried to make their voices sound deeper than they actually were confounded her, as it seemed counter-productive to voluntarily sound like crap, but then again, there were a lot of weird people in this world.

"What if I'm gay?" she quietly asks herself.

The only problem was that she wasn't exactly attracted to men, and therefore she couldn't be gay. But saying "no" to that question felt…incomplete, and she couldn't figure out why. She had asked herself this question what felt like a thousand times already, and of course, she wasn't into men like she was women. She had even looked up gay porn just to find out, but it only turned her off, though she had a weird vague attraction to men she couldn't quite put into words which made her feel uncomfortable. Not that straight porn was a cornucopia to her, but she could get off to it.

She definitely felt attracted to women, but also in a bit of a weird way. She felt jealous that women got to wear such nicer outfits than she could, had friendships that seemed like actual friendships, didn't have to worry about their voices dropping or having facial hair… If she put on a skirt or a dress, she'd get ridiculed for it, but women could do that every day if they so desired. She was attracted to women in a kind of abstract sense, one that she couldn't entirely figure out, and it weirded her out. Kissing a girl seemed like it would be nice, but sex just seemed wrong, and she couldn't put her finger on why, though she certainly wasn't trying to figure out why, either.

One time, while home alone, she had put on one of her mom's dresses, an abstract floral design that had always felt like it was calling to her since she first saw it on her mom. When she looked at herself in the mirror, she was struck with feelings of wanting *more,* that she was supposed to dress like that, and immense shame for having actually gone through with it, feeling like a pervert. Disgust began to fill her soon after, feeling like a gross man in a dress, and she quickly hung it back up just as she found it. Though she desperately wanted to do it again, she couldn't bring herself to, knowing she had to take that secret to her grave. It had only made her more confused as to if she was gay or not.

She had two good friends at school, both of whom she had originally met in kindergarten, and one of whom she had been in the same classes as until middle school. Now that they were in different rotations, the only class they shared was band. When all the seventh graders got let out to mill about the track and soccer fields on Thursday afternoons in place of homeroom, they always stuck together. She didn't do much of the talking, but she enjoyed the feeling of being social without having to put much of herself out there.

She much preferred being friends with girls to guys, but in middle school, guys can't be "just friends" with girls, so these two guys were basically the only good friends she had left. Not that she was close with them, but she didn't feel like she was desperately searching for the right social script like she oftentimes did around her other classmates, especially since they shared a similar "dark" (read: edgy 4channer) sense of humor, so she felt like she fit in quite well with them, especially since one of them was also a fan of the new *My Little Pony* reboot.

A couple Thursdays ago, their conversation had strayed to gay people. That morning, while waiting in the cafeteria for the homeroom bell to sound, she had been debating whether homosexuality is real when one of the guys she knew from her scout troop claimed it was real but that it was a choice. She, of course, disagreed, since nobody of a sound mind would voluntarily sign themselves up for exile by choosing to be attracted to men if it actually was a choice. She could never get it up for a man, so it must be wired into your brain if you actually like men. He responded by saying that he chose to be attracted to women, and it wasn't that hard, so he didn't see why gay people chose the "lifestyle."

It was something she couldn't argue against, assuming he was telling the truth (and she couldn't think of any way to prove otherwise), but that didn't seem right. She had read a decent amount on reddit about being gay, and it definitely wasn't a choice. But her little flip phone couldn't open reddit, much less find the threads she had read that in. All she could do was ask the rest of the people involved in the debate if they had chosen to be attracted to women, of whom none had, but that didn't seem to deter the one who was convinced it was a choice. Their stalemate was only broken when the bell rung and they went to their lockers, but the conversation about gay people resumed when the three of them met up on the track that afternoon.

"So, like, are you gay or something? Cuz you seemed pretty invested in that debate with Chris this morning," one of her friends asked.

"I feel like a male lesbian," she absentmindedly responded. It was true, but if she had actually thought before she spoke, she probably would have said "no, but I've met a gay person and I

think he deserves respect" or something similar. She immediately began to internally panic that she might have made a huge mistake by saying that, with suicidal thoughts already churning in her mind, but her friends just started laughing, thinking she was pulling their legs.

"Hell yeah, I'm a lesbian too, I'd fuck girls," he shot back, his voice dripping with sarcasm. It really rubbed her the wrong way, conflating being a lesbian with just being into women, regardless of gender. But she didn't respond, feeling guilty for even having voiced the weird feelings she had about being gay *but in the other way.* She felt guilty for even feeling that way to begin with. Obviously, men couldn't be lesbians, but she couldn't ignore how it seemed to fit in her mind. She knew part of the guilt stemmed from how she had begun to despise the oversexualization of women and everything they do (and feeling like a "male lesbian" just added to the problem), but she dared not investigate any other reasons for her feelings, being afraid of what she would find.

"Am I gay?" she whispers to herself as she stares at the ceiling, focusing in on a small spot where the painters got lazy and didn't tape it off properly, a small splash of blue against the white paint above her, looking like the wall was encroaching on the ceiling. It was the only way she knew to be different except things like race or religion, and before she had said it aloud, the "male lesbian" thing was easy to ignore, but now she couldn't. Every time she asked herself this question, that label popped back into her head. And the best answer she could come up with was "yes, but in the wrong way." It scared her.

She knew her father was very conservative, and since she was the only one defending gay people at the table that day, the last thing

she wanted was for people to think of her as being that. It was something she would take to her grave – that she was into women meant she was a straight man and didn't have to worry about discrimination, especially since she was white, from an upper-middle class family, and raised in the church. It's probably for the best not to rock that boat.

Denial

The next night marked another Christmas where she had to plaster on a smile and say thanks for the gifts she barely cared for. For Aaron, the magic of Christmas disappearing (which had to be in the second grade at the latest) marked the beginning of her faking smiles, being unable to understand why anyone would voluntarily spend money on gifts for her. She didn't think she deserved them, and frankly, she didn't really care about them all that much. It was nice, but it felt like other people deserved the money spent on her more than she did. She only made a Christmas list to keep her parents off her case, and in a few short weeks, she would plaster on a smile once more for her thirteenth birthday. But for now, she absentmindedly browses Wikipedia, already having ten tabs open less than ten minutes into this binge. As she closes the page on Homosexuality, having read enough to be sure she was correct that it wasn't a choice, the next tab pops into a view, a page on a topic she had never heard of before.

> Transgender

> Transgender is a general term applied to a variety of individuals, behaviors, and groups involving tendencies to vary from the usual gender roles.

Aaron can't help but feel a strange connection to the term, and she can't figure out why. There seems to be something fitting about it, like *male lesbian*, and in much the same way, it scares her. She nearly closes the tab, afraid of what she might find out, but continues on, telling herself that this isn't her, that this is the exact opposite of her, that if she was actually transgender, she

wouldn’t be so afraid. Even though she only had to prove to herself that this was pure coincidence (and could convince herself she already had if she put her mind to it), she continued on, not wanting it to nag at her later on and draw her back in when she didn’t have privacy.

> Transgender is the state of one's "gender identity" (self-identification as woman, man, neither or both) not matching one's "assigned sex" (identification by others as male, female or intersex based on physical/genetic sex). "Transgender" does not imply any specific form of sexual orientation; transgender people may identify as heterosexual, homosexual, bisexual, pansexual, polysexual, or asexual; some may consider conventional sexual orientation labels inadequate or inapplicable to them. …

By the time she gets to the end, she has opened an additional ten tabs. But before reading through them, she decides to see what reddit has to say about it, figuring the less formal writing would help her more. Though she usually just lurked, she could always make a post with questions. Then they could tell her she wasn’t transgender, and she could live her life being slightly more knowledgeable, with the reassurance that whatever she is would probably be more socially acceptable than this. But her feelings betray her, with her hands shaking with nervousness and making it difficult for her to type properly. Eventually, she stumbles across a subreddit that seems like it might be useful, /r/AskTransgender, and one of the first posts she reads on the page takes her breath away.

> I think I might be transgender (21 m)

> So… My entire life, I don't think I've ever really 'fit in' as a guy. I've mostly had male friends, and I've lived as a straight male, but

growing up, my closest friends have been girls. …

By the time she finishes reading through the post and comments, it takes everything in her to avoid closing the browser. Part of her mind is screaming to get away from this, that nothing good will come out of it, but she wants – *needs* – to know more. *This could be it,* she thinks, thankful to finally have a word that described her, but also utterly terrified by its implications. She continues to read through the posts on the subreddit, soon starting a text file to save all the threads she found useful. Occasionally, memories from her childhood pop up, like being confused about why she had to get clothes from the "boys" sides of stores, but she does her best to push them out of her mind, already beginning to desperately search for ways to prove she was not transgender. It was a fate that seemed worse than death, and she was determined to make sure it wouldn't become true.

When she glances at the clock in the taskbar next, she almost jumps. It's past midnight, and she's still got eighteen tabs open. Over the past four hours, much of what she had read all pointed to the same conclusion. But also over the past four hours, much of what she had read made her want it to be anything but. She would much rather be a gay man than a trans woman, straight or not. Sure, she still would be hated, but she would be hated *less*, and there were certainly more gay people in existence considering she actually knew one. She didn't know any trans people. Even if she could ever pass, she would probably never be accepted by anyone who knew the truth. She would be viewed as a predator, would get disowned by her family, deal with all kinds of harassment, have to change her name…and even if she could get on HRT, that was no guarantee for passing, and it wouldn't do anything about her voice.

"I'm such a failure, a disgrace," she whispers to herself as she holds back tears, the monitor beginning to dim from inactivity as she continues to sit in silence, agonizing over everything she's read, doing everything she can to poke holes in the idea that this label was the one for her. *I've never thought about wanting a vagina before, only now that I've read about it, so I can't be trans,* she thinks. *If I was actually trans, I would have known I was a girl when I was young. I would have been insistent about it. The closest thing I have in common with these people is that I largely resisted having my hair cut short, but that was because men's hairstyles are just objectively worse, and I just wanted something nice. And I would have to be straight – or rather, a gay man – because straight men can't be trans women. I have to be faking it, there's nothing to prove I'm trans.*

As she slinks to the bathroom to get ready for bed, the thoughts continue, that her desire to have breasts was because she was a disgusting pervert who just wanted to jerk off to herself in the mirror (even though the idea seemed appalling to her), that even if she was truly trans and somehow managed to get a doctor to refer her to an endocrinologist, she would never pass and would be seen as a freak. That she would never be able to date anybody if she was trans besides gay men scraping the bottom of the barrel.

And in a feat of mental gymnastics that would impress her with its absurdity when she remembered it in the future, she finally swallowed an argument she had read and decided that the transphobes were right – she could not be trans because trans people didn't exist before the 1960s, so it had to be a bunch of academics and elites trying to normalize their cross-dressing fetish and trick straight men into sleeping with them. That these people were trying to seem relatable to everyone, that most people would think they're trans if they read the stuff she had, and she was never going to stoop to their level. Part of her knew it was

illogical (and seemed like a bit of a dog whistle, though she didn’t know the term yet), but what was most important to her was convincing herself that it wasn’t true, that she was just a straight boy with a normal childhood, and the more she repeated it, the more she began to internalize it.

Anger

"Why did it have to be *me?*" Aaron grunts as she slams her foot into a package on the floor, making a noticeable dent, though it didn't slide more than a couple inches with its weight. Part of her knows she shouldn't do this, but she can't punch a hole in the wall or act out at school, or her parents will know something's up (or so she imagines), and she can't risk any outside attention. She sends a few more kicks into the box while bemoaning her fate, knowing they've seen FedEx treat packages far worse on numerous occasions, and given the website this was ordered from, it'll be replaced if she actually damages it. Her denial had been slowly wearing off, and with it, her usual emotionless existence had been interrupted by mounting anger at why it had to be her, why these feelings had to torture her, what she did to deserve this, and now, it had gotten to the point that she couldn't ignore it. Usually, she could ride out emotional turmoil by letting it starve itself by just doing nothing, but today, she found herself overwhelmed.

"I tried to do everything right and this is where it gets me!" she yells at the box as she slams into it again, the toe cap on her boot colliding with a solid wall of packing material that squeaks on contact – Styrofoam, no doubt – and creating a small hole in the cardboard. She stops to catch her breath and spots Adam's cat, Whiskers, black on white and definitely overweight, giving an annoyed look before putting his head back down on the couch to resume his nap. Swift Wind had come down to say hello, but when she dropped the package, the noise scared him off. As she pushes the box to rest next to the door, her white terrier approaches, and her anger lifts as he gives her a warm welcome. Thankfully, her parents aren't here, and her brother has baseball practice, otherwise they'd probably be all over her for how she just treated that box.

Upstairs, as she washes her hands after using the bathroom, she scowls at the mirror. She tried to fit in, be the good child, attend church without whining about it like her brother, follow the rules, do her homework, study, and despite all the good that's *supposed* to do, this curse still infected her. And she was taught about how good the Lord is, that He's a merciful god…some mercy she's been shown in life. If God had His plan, how the fuck did she fit into it? Was she supposed to just kill herself? Because that's what her brain has been telling her to do, and surely God would have stopped the thoughts if that's what He wanted. He could have made her cis, made her be born a woman, made her not be hated for merely existing, hell, He could have just made her gay. At least that was more likely to be accepted by society than being trans. Obviously, she wasn't Jesus, yet she still seemed to have been put on this planet to live in agony.

She had prayed. Oh, how she had prayed when she was young, knowing there was something wrong with her and hoping to be cured. She prayed even now, hoping desperately that she would finally be healed. She had been patient, yet everything had only gotten worse for her. Her suicidal thoughts, her hatred for her voice, her jealousy of girls… Because at this point, the only hope for this to go away is if God wills it. But He didn't seem to be listening. Or perhaps He's trying to tell her to just jump in front of a bus or a train…it seems more logical than the alternative, that He just wants her to suffer. A good chunk of her seriously doubts that the information she's been taught was even partially accurate when you consider it was humans who transcribed the Bible, duplicated it, translated it, and then were put in charge of interpreting it for thousands of years, each with their own agenda and preconceptions, and the idea that there was a serious whitewashing campaign and the Lord was actually a vindictive bastard didn't seem so farfetched to her.

"'God works in mysterious ways,' *my ass,*" she mutters. He doesn't seem to work at all. Heck, He probably just chills with Jesus and watches the shitshow unfold for entertainment all day. It's not like He can be held accountable or anything.

"Why the fuck should I believe in a god who has clearly abandoned me? I've been fucking faithful, and I've been *really* fucking patient, and this is where it gets me? I've never had anything approaching proof that He even exists. And if the preacher is telling the truth, that gay people can't get to heaven, then why the hell were they put on the Earth to begin with? Why would a 'merciful' God allow anyone to exist who is unable to ever earn His favor?" she screams at the mirror. "Why was I put here? Just to suffer?"

Her rant would likely have continued but for the scratching at the door. When she opens it, a very worried looking Swift Wind runs in, trying his best to comfort her as she continues to grapple with her religion, which felt like it was slipping through her fingers, and with it, the last hope of being cured. She knew she was different from the other kids at her school, but didn't want to add religion (or lack thereof) to the list of things that made her stand out, and to the list of things that would probably upset her parents. Though he couldn't understand her, he felt like the closest thing to a confidant she had at this point, and she desperately hugs him as she cries for the first time in years. Her parents she certainly didn't trust with this, nor her brother, who seemed to mirror their dad's political views, and the closest friends she had at school never seemed like they would be super accepting of any LGBT people. "I wish I had someone else to talk to," she whispers through her sobs. She would give *anything* for it not to be true, for her thoughts to go away, to be normal.

Back when the only way she knew how to be different was being gay, the world seemed a lot less scary to her, but now she dreaded waking up in the morning, especially as she began to notice more changes to her body. She had completely dissociated during sex ed and had next to no memory of what they talked about there, but after looking up a timeline of the effects of puberty in boys, it only made her even more fearful of what was to come. She had started going to sleep earlier, trying to minimize her time awake and thus reduce her suffering, but part of her worried that it was only speeding things up.

"No, I can't be trans, please, God, it has to be something else," she whimpers as she lapses back into denial, feeling utterly hopeless that her situation will ever get any better.

Bargaining

Hearing the front door open, Aaron kills her recording software and closes the tabs she had been looking at. Judging by the time, her mother was returning home, and she wasn't going to risk doing anything now. Every day that her father was at work and her brother had to stay afterschool for baseball, she had rushed home to work on her voice training. She had rationalized it away by telling herself it was just because she hated her voice, thus keeping it independent of if she was back in denial or not because it was just a matter of sound, not gender (despite the obvious doublethink being employed by someone who liked to fancy herself rational).

At this point, she could make herself sound somewhat androgynous, but she still had a long way to go, and there wasn't much time before baseball season would be over, soon to be followed by summer break. Her mother would go and teach college classes before too long, but her brother didn't have a job or anything to reliably keep him out of the house, so unless he went to hang out elsewhere, there was nothing she could do without bringing attention to herself. Even the backyard was risky with the reduction in trees for her neighbor's latest landscaping project.

Since she had completed her homework on the bus, there was nothing for her to do but try to distract herself, and without voice training, all she had left were her forums and video games since she basically never saw anyone outside of school anymore unless she got invited to a birthday party. It was depressing to think about, especially since she used to be so social that she got diagnosed with ADHD and put on medication to reduce the

amount of trouble she got in for goofing off at school, but she couldn't break the cycle of socially withdrawing. She didn't have the motivation to try, nor the self-confidence to follow through on it, and she hated it.

But self-isolation had become her norm – it felt safe now, not to have people expecting her to be social – and given that her teachers seemed to like it (and subsequently, her parents), she had no reason to stop. After all, being social could expose her if she let her guard down, so she had resigned herself to her two "friends" and only talking as needed to those around her.

Her brother was the exact opposite, having only gotten more social over the years (though still nowhere near the chatterbox she was in elementary school). It was something she was sometimes picked on for – rarely speaking and never showing emotion, while her brother was so full of life – but it felt like a small price to pay compared to the hell which she imagined awaited her if she were to say why things changed.

The most she felt she could safely do was play as women in video games. She hadn't even realized she was doing it at first, but when she was looking at the family tree for her current *Sims 3* save a few weeks ago, it hit her. She usually started out playing a new game with a traditional nuclear family (always spending the most time customizing the mother and any daughters while typically randomizing the guys in Create a Sim) and would immediately go to work getting the husband out of the picture, either by "accident" or divorce. With a single mother, she was then free to romance with other girls in whichever world she was playing and settle down with one of them, living the life she wished she could have. Usually there was at least one cat in the

family, and sometimes she put Swift Wind in as a horse (or a unicorn, if she found one).

With the children, if there was only a son, she would get him married, then divorce the two and kick the guy out of the house. If there was a daughter, after getting any sons out of the picture (either by dumping them on the father during the divorce or marrying them off as soon as they were able), she would romance the girls in the area as soon as was possible, usually having them get married and adopt eventually. Her current save file was on its fifth generation – the initial nuclear family she broke up, the son she kicked out of the house in favor of the daughter-in-law, and two generations of women marrying and adopting baby girls. When she loaded up her other save files to see if she had always been doing this, she could only find two heterosexual couples she hadn't divorced or otherwise separated.

It was almost comical how hard she was self-inserting, but the humor was lost on her in her worrying over just how far back it went as she loaded her *Sims 2* save files to find a similar pattern of always playing as women (though she had to install a mod to allow for her couples to marry instead of just having a "joined union"). She had known she had a habit of picking girl names for mayors in *SimCity 4* since she had to actually think about it (she rationalized it by deciding she preferred some "variety" on the region view), but this was a complete surprise to her. She knew she usually randomized men in Create a Sim since she always felt a bit weird while trying to find outfits that worked for them, but she had completely isolated that in her mind, never thinking any deeper beyond "well I'm straight; gay men know about fashion, I don't."

Part of her wanted to delete her saves and uninstall the games entirely in response, but given that they were the only games that let her live a life she'd enjoy, she couldn't bring herself to remove them. After all, those games weren't real, they were just an escape, and one she desperately needed as the weight of everything gradually got heavier. She still wasn't close to accepting what she was, even in the face of what she had realized, but wasn't about to let her preferred form of escapism get swallowed up, to be collateral damage from her swirling emotions. She had even been doing it back when she was obsessed with *Lego Star Wars,* always playing as Jango Fett in free play mode, even though Boba Fett was an objectively better character due to his blaster.

Because she hadn't seen the prequels when she first played through the game, she assumed Jango was a girl because of the purple armor (and Jango wasn't a name that registered as male or female to her). That Jango had a son seemed perfectly logical – she must be a mom. When she watched *Attack of the Clones* and found out Jango was a man, she was incredibly disappointed and stopped playing as him entirely. And until her most recent emotional turmoil, she had completely forgotten about it.

At one point, her brother had noticed her family composition when he stepped in to ask a question while she was in the bathroom, and the only excuse she could think up with was "lesbians are hot." And he bought it, agreeing with her and thinking nothing more of it while Aaron felt disgusted by her words. She couldn't shake the feeling that she was fetishizing lesbians (and women in general), and the guilt over feeling like a "male lesbian" returned. Not that she ever got off to the game, nor did she ever dress her characters in revealing outfits (even the athletic and swimwear outfits she chose were fairly conservative), and she had basically given up on porn for how gross it tended to make her feel, but some of the transphobic rhetoric she had read

continued to haunt her, telling her this was just a sexual thing and that she was a creep for it.

"I'm never going to transition; I'll never be able to. But even if I could, it would be too risky. The most I could ever do is be a femboy, and even that is unlikely," she tells herself as she watches the loading screen for her Sunset Valley save. "I have this, and that's good enough. It's a fantasy, a *fetish*, and at least in this, I don't have to worry about projecting it onto anyone else. I can control this." Part of her knows it's a lie, but it's a comforting one, if for no other reason than the idea that she can contain it, bottling it up and living a normal life, being able to be someone her parents can be proud of.

When it finally finishes loading, she moves the camera to an eye-level view of the room, incredibly pink and fluffy, like something out of a Barbie commercial. Every time she designed a room like this, she told herself she was just making it for the characters who would inhabit it (even if they were guys), but she knew it wasn't the whole truth. When she thought about it, it was weird to live vicariously through a series of data structures represented as pixels on a screen, but it was the best she could imagine ever having, the only thing she could ever allow herself to have.

Depression

"Let's say I come out now and somehow it goes great, everyone accepts me, even at school, I pass within a year…then what? It doesn't change what's happened before, it doesn't change the fact that I'll never be a woman," Aaron whispers to herself as she waits for sleep to come. "It probably won't change how isolated I've become or fix my depression. I'll probably still want to kill myself, which would make me twice the freak, really."

"I just want to be a mother, to be able to have kids, but that won't happen in my lifetime. And even if I did have breasts, I couldn't breastfeed a child without drugs to induce lactation."

As much as she wants to cry, knowing it would make her feel better, there are no tears to shed. She had been able to practically cry on command before she hit puberty. Now, her emotions had to be turned up to eleven for that to even be a possibility, and to say that was rare would be an understatement. Even when one of her grandfathers died last year, the one she loved spending time with, not a single tear came, even when she read the final stanza of "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" at his wake (though she had come close). For the past few months, she had been an emotionless husk once again, and in just a couple weeks, school would be starting back.

Testosterone took her emotions away from her aside from varying shades of mediocrity. She felt so empty inside, like nothing could ever fill the void. That trans men even existed – people who would voluntarily take testosterone – seemed batshit insane to

her, being able to only imagine being a man as being an emotionless husk like herself. Certainly, men couldn't talk about their emotions to friends, or at least, not unless they wanted to be seen as effeminate, which she had seen kids get picked on at her school for before. That she could talk about her emotions somewhat openly with her girl friends, back when boys and girls could be just friends, had been a lifeline for her, and now she felt like she was being slowly pulled under by the growing emotional burden she dared not to share with anyone. The last time she had said anything remotely vulnerable – the "male lesbian" comment – it was treated as a joke. She didn't trust anyone to take her seriously after that, except perhaps serious enough to toss her into an asylum.

Not that that seemed like such a terrible idea right about now – then she wouldn't have to worry about being homeless, it would make her less likely to be the victim of a hate crime, and people could tell her how delusional she was being, wanting to be a woman. Sometimes she resorted to self-harm to try and "beat out" the thoughts (using her fists because the bruises from that didn't last more than an hour, unlike cutting, which would be incredibly obvious to her mom), and being told she was crazy might help with that, she felt. Not that she knew much about mental hospitals, but that was how she expected she would be treated, with much of her knowledge coming from stories she had read on the pre-pharmaceutical approaches to mental health. She tried not to think about it, though – really, she just tried to not think about whether she was trans or not through escapism.

Over the summer, the only social interaction she had (outside her family and retail workers) was staying up late on Skype with her two friends from school, playing *Minecraft* until they were close to passing out from exhaustion. The game had lost its luster for her a while ago (even Redstone engineering was starting to become a chore instead of a fun challenge), but it was the only video game

they all owned, enjoyed, and which let them host private servers. As much as she loved *Portal 2*, the multiplayer was just two-person co-op, and though she had recently become addicted to *OpenTTD* (sometimes getting sucked in for an entire week), the other two didn't see the appeal. *Minecraft* was her only dependable form of social interaction, oftentimes being the last to drop off the call at 2 AM and shut down the Hamachi network.

Spending her break like this was taking its toll, amplifying her depression. At one point, she left her programming projects untouched for two weeks, unable to bring herself to do anything other than try to distract herself by spending the day on reddit. And though she was usually a bookworm, she hadn't touched a single book in almost a month. Despite Marlena only being able to observe Aaron eating less (and not everything that happened while she was at work), she could tell something was up, and had asked if everything was alright. But Aaron staunchly denied there were any problems and continued to repeat that she was perfectly fine until her mom gave up, figuring it was just puberty doing its thing and that giving some space was the best response.

The questions had left Aaron a bit panicked, and when her brother had to start spending weekdays at football camp, she almost didn't restart her voice training out of fear she was being watched through hidden cameras. Part of her felt it was useless to work on her voice when she wasn't trans (or so she kept telling herself), that it was hopeless, even though she preferred hearing an androgynous voice when she thought out loud to a masculine one (and would much prefer a feminine one). Eventually, she worked up the nerve to resume her work, but she only had a few weeks before school started back.

Sometimes, she found it hard to eat lunch. Because why bother? There was no one around to tell her to eat, nothing that required her to eat three meals a day. She could keep optimizing her routes in *OpenTTD* if she skipped lunch, after all. She wouldn't have to worry about getting to a stopping point or resuming later on and potentially forgetting some of the longer-term projects she was working on. It seemed useless to head downstairs and plate a sandwich or heat up leftovers when she would be eating dinner in a few hours, anyway. If taking her ADHD medication on an empty stomach didn't make her feel nauseous, she would probably start skipping breakfast, too.

After her mom started questioning her, she began taking the ingredients for a sandwich out of the fridge and putting them in the trash to make it seem like she had eaten lunch, covering them with paper plates to disguise her work. Part of her felt bad for doing it, but she usually couldn't bring herself to eat unless others were watching (or having the threat of feeling nauseous), despite the suicidal thoughts that usually got triggered by this charade.

Her only moments of happiness this summer had come when she went down to New Jersey for BronyCon, but even then, she had a close call when one of her friends whom she had met online, Perfuma, joked "There are two types of Bronies: women, and those who haven't realized it yet." In that moment, it felt like she had been seen right through, that she was about to get outed in front of the small group of friends she had previously only known through forum posts and Skype calls, but nobody was looking at her as they laughed, so she nervously joined in. To this day, she has no idea what Perfuma really thinks of her, being too afraid to ask, but her friend has never said anything about gender to her, so she can only hope that she hasn't been figured out.

“But what if I am trans? Then what’s all this even for? What am I putting off?” she mumbles as she shifts to look at the wall beside her. Occasionally, bits of light flicker against it when the status lights on her computer blink, a reminder of just how alone she feels, more isolated than ever before.

Her only response is to try to ignore the possibility that’s been glaring her in the face, not wanting to seriously think about what it would mean for her and her self-destructive actions.

Acceptance

When the thermometer finally beeps, Aaron pulls it out of her mouth and reads the result. *101.3 F.* She quickly keys it in and sends the text to her mom before walking back to her bedroom, followed closely by Swift Wind. She was the only one here, having come down with the flu the day before they were supposed to see their cousins in Chicago.

Her mom had offered to stay and help take care of her, but she had insisted she could handle herself. She would feel incredibly guilty if anyone sacrificed their trip to stay behind and babysit her, but she was also glad that she avoided having to interact with her extended family. She always felt out of place at those events, the quiet one who always kept to a book instead of interacting, or when she was social, it was usually with the adults rather than the others her age, much the same way that she tended to interact with the leaders more readily than her fellow scouts when her troop went on camping trips. She didn't necessarily feel more comfortable talking with the adults, just more comfortable with the topics on their minds, likely because they weren't centered around school, where she always felt out of place.

"Here's to another day of misery," she mutters as she downs the small cup of pills she had prepared, eventually giving in and using water to wash it down her sore throat. Even in her current state, her feminine voice is acceptable (and with nobody else around, it's her default). She wraps her blanket around her tighter as she debates if she should eat breakfast or try to go back to sleep and let the medicine kick in. She was still incredibly tired despite having slept until just before noon and was in no mood to take a shower.

Thinking back to how she had to scrape together a meal last night, she decides to get some groceries delivered. Since her parents had thought nobody would be here for over a week, the perishables were all gone, in addition to all the bread and soup, and to say she was hungry was an understatement. She might feel up for biking over when the medicine kicks in, but if she doesn't, that's all the more time she'll be waiting for food to get delivered. Plus, she had her mom's primary credit card memorized, and she had been given permission to get something to eat, so why not try getting groceries delivered for once?

After placing an order on her desktop, she slowly makes her way down the stairs to take care of Swift Wind and the cats, planning on taking her confidant for a walk once she has some food in her and doesn't feel like death.

With the pets fed, she takes a nap in the living room, at least until it's interrupted by a knock at the door, followed by barking, and she quickly remembers what she ordered about an hour ago. "Thought they'd be busier than this," she mutters as she pulls herself up and looks at the clock. When she stands, she decides she doesn't need the blanket anymore, being nice and toasty from her hoodie and sweatpants. There's another round of knocking at the door as she trudges over, telling Swift Wind to quiet down as she checks to make sure her tip is still in her pocket.

"I've got an order for Marlena Grayskull," the delivery man greets as she opens the door, her hoodie still partially drawn over her face, and what was showing partially obscured by her long, blonde hair, which she hadn't bothered attempting to tame, not

wanting to do it while sore before and not really having the energy yet.

"Yeah, I can take it," Aaron replies, not paying attention to what voice she uses as she watches Swift Wind inspect the mystery man. "Do I keep these bags, or do you need me to hand them back when I finish unloading them?"

"They don't go back to the store, they're yours to keep. Do you need any help bringing them in?"

"Nah, I got this," she tells the man as she picks up the two large bags and brings them to the kitchen counter. When she returns to the door to get Swift Wind back inside, the man has already begun getting familiar with him, and her dog is loving the attention.

"I love your dog, I used to have a terrier when I was young. What's his name?"

"His name is Swift Wind, and as you can see, he's very friendly," Aaron replies as she pulls out a $10 bill from her pocket. She can't help but smile at how trusting Swift Wind still is. Even when they first saw him in the pet store, he was practically rolling over for anyone who so much as looked in his general direction, and almost nothing had changed since then. He was going to be traveling with them for their vacation, but with her staying behind, she was going to be caring for him like usual. She was glad that her parents had decided to leave him with her, as he always

seemed to be able to cheer her up, which was exactly what she needed right about now.

"You're such a good boy, Swift Wind, and you have a really cool name," the delivery man tells the dog before noticing the money waiting for him and turning to face Aaron. "Oh, thank you, ma'am. I just need you to sign a receipt to confirm everything was delivered."

Aaron doesn't think twice as she scrawls out a nearly unintelligible signature, but when the man calls out "Have a nice day, miss," as he walks back to his truck, it hits her: she just passed. And she wasn't even trying. As soon as she shuts the door, she rushes to the bathroom and looks in the mirror. What was visible of her face looked somewhat feminine (if only due to her hair), but her voice spoke for itself. She passed to a complete stranger.

"Did he really just use 'miss'?" she whispers to herself as she works to control her breathing, backtracking and replaying his words in her mind. "And 'ma'am'?" She had been ma'am'd before on the phone before her voice dropped, but she always ignored it because they couldn't see who was on the other end of the receiver (and phones distort sound). But this time was in person, and given that he had already gotten a tip, he didn't have to worry about getting stiffed if he acted rude at that point. What just happened made her positively giddy, so happy that she could probably ignore how awful her body was feeling and run around the neighborhood, and she nearly cried tears of joy. *This must be how Pinkie Pie feels when she's excited*, she thinks. *Where has this feeling been all my life?*

It had been a long time since Aaron had truly felt happy about anything, and she can't remember any interaction with a stranger ever making her feel like this before. And she wanted more, so much more – this, she realized, was how she was meant to be.

The next couple days were one giant emotional high for her, still being insanely happy from that incident. She actually ate properly despite having nobody there to watch her, and even cleaned her room, a long-overdue task she hadn't had the energy for until now. It had been a long time since she genuinely smiled, but getting gendered correctly had left her grinning from ear to ear as she replayed the interaction in her mind. It had taken a lot of effort to make herself sound somewhat normal (or rather, sick) when her mom had called to check up on her to avoid raising suspicions that she had somehow faked the flu, and she was pretty sure she hadn't put on the greatest performance considering her mom asked if she was feeling better already, but it felt like nothing could stop her happiness.

But it couldn't last forever, of course, and when it wore off in the night, it hit her hard in the morning, even harder than the flu had. She wanted more of that validation – to be seen as a woman, and not just once, but *always*. She wanted to use her girl voice in public, rough as it may still be. She wanted to wear the clothes she had been jealous of for years, to have breasts, to be a woman, despite the crap women have to deal with for simply existing.

She had still been holding out hope for something that would prove to her that she wasn't trans, that it was something else, but she couldn't keep living in denial with that staring her in the face; there was no other explanation. And as much as she wanted to come out, to transition, to live the life she so desperately wanted,

she was afraid of the reactions she would get – from her parents, brother, extended family, teachers, classmates…everyone.

"I am trans," she whimpers as the tears begin to flow, devastated by the truth she had been desperately running from for almost a year. All the things she had read online and thought about suddenly flooded back to her, of all the pain that transitioning entailed, the difficulties she would face in life, the knowledge of her dad's politics, the fact that she didn't trust her parents enough to even consider coming out while still living under their roof, how long it would be until she could move away for college, how long until she had any hope of transitioning. That the only thing she could really do for now was to keep working on her voice and fight against the effects of testosterone as much as she could while hoping she didn't inherit the early male pattern baldness from her dad's side of the family.

"I'm sorry, Swift Wind, I am a fucking woman after all," she whispers to her companion between sobs, not having the energy to try to deny it or the mental willpower to keep up the losing battle any longer. "I've been such a fool to try and run from this, and now I'm at the end of the line until I move out. I hope you're not mad at me."

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, that bit about debating whether or not being gay is a choice is an actual conversation I had when I was in middle school. In hindsight, he was probably bisexual, but I didn't know that was a thing at the time.

What's in a Name?

Chapter Notes

CW for suicide, transphobic slurs, misgendering, and trauma.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You'll never fucking pass, nobody will ever like you, you unlovable *freak*."

Aaron sat on the floor of the bathroom forcing back tears, a bottle of water in her left hand. A bottle of extra strength Tylenol with the cap off lay on the floor, and a small mountain of pills sat in her right hand as she tried to work up the courage to take them. If she could just down them and hold off on saying anything for a couple days, it would surely put her down. A relief from the never-ending misery that was her life, trapped in a body she despised with all her being and which only seemed to be getting worse.

Her most recent depression spiral had taken her to depths she hadn't known before, and she had found herself posting pictures on 4chan's /lgbt/ seeking confirmation of her worst fears, which she readily received, pushing her over the edge. They might have been raiders from /pol/, but she didn't care; to her, it was what she needed to hear to finally go through with it.

"Just do it, it's not worth living, you worthless piece of shit," she kept telling herself, followed by, "But what if it doesn't work? What if they're able to save my sorry ass and everyone at school will ridicule me for being a worthless tranny?"

Her original plan had been to jump onto the highway behind her school, but due to construction, the eastbound lanes were moving too slowly for that to work, and the westbound ones were too empty, so she ran home to figure out something else. Her parents had several guns in the house, and her dad had a stash of razor blades, but this method wouldn't require cleaning up tons of blood and gore, and the last thing she wanted was to be a burden to her family. Splattering her worthless corpse all over the room would only make her parents hate her even more than if they knew the truth, she reasoned.

"Nobody would ever want to be around me if they knew. If I don't do this, I'll probably be disowned and thrown out, maybe even committed to an asylum."

Her back-and-forth continued for what felt like an eternity until she heard the front door open, and she knew it was now or never.

Panicking, she forced as many pills down as she could while trying not to cry, some of them missing her mouth and falling to the ground, but many making their way in. When her right hand was emptied, she began to pick up the pills that spilled on the floor to down the rest of them, but as she began to think about what she had just done, she dropped them. Her thoughts began swinging like a pendulum, unable to decide if the mistake was choosing death or just this particular method, and with each passing moment, she began to wish she hadn't done anything at all. Feeling helpless, she gave in to the tears she had been struggling to suppress, feeling like a failure of a human being, someone who didn't deserve to be on this planet, a biological mistake.

Her sobbing (and the continued pawing of the door by Swift Wind) soon attracted the attention of her mother, who ignored the groceries she just brought in, charging up the stairs to investigate and rapping on the bathroom door.

"Aaron? Is that you?" she called out, a sinking feeling developing in the pit of her stomach. The only response she got was continued sobbing, which just made her more worried. After asking a second time and still not getting a verbal response, she warned that she was coming in before unlocking it.

As Marlena entered the room, color drained from her face at the sight of Aaron with her head against her knees holding a water bottle, a bottle of Tylenol and pills spilled on the floor. Part of her had felt something was wrong the moment she had unlocked the front door, but she had brushed it off until she heard the crying. Even if she had investigated immediately, nothing could have prepared her for this.

She immediately dropped to her knees and hugged her child, struggling to contain her panicking, barely able to think through what she needed to do next.

"Aaron, are you alright? Please talk to me."

"I want to die," is all Aaron could get out, ashamed and dreading what would happen to her next. If she even lived, how her parents would view her after, the mentally ill freak who couldn't even kill herself and caused a huge panic when she probably should've been left to rot.

“Did you take any of these pills?” her mom desperately asked, already knowing the answer but holding out hope that she would be wrong. When she got no response, she added, “Please, Aaron, I need to know.”

“Yes,” the younger one squeaked out.

Marlena’s skin went several shades lighter at the reply, confirming her worst fears and cutting through the hope she was desperately clinging to. “Oh God, no, please tell me you’re joking. How many did you take?”

“A lot.”

“Oh god, we need to go to the hospital. We need to go,” she kept repeating to herself as she struggled to keep from hyperventilating while she desperately tried to pull Aaron up from the ground, but to no avail.

Aaron was not ready to accept her fate, paralyzed by her conflicting emotions of being thankful that someone wanted to help her and desperately wanting to accept that help but upset and ashamed that she was caught, wanting to die so that she wouldn’t be such a burden to everyone else anymore. Her suicidal thoughts only seemed to get worse, wishing she would have a heart attack or something, to just die, or better yet, to have never existed to at all, because she didn’t deserve to live if she couldn’t even get this right. She was locked in place and couldn’t move

until her mom threatened to call the cops, with the thought of being cuffed, dragged out, and possibly beaten finally breaking the stalemate.

During the ride, Marlena drove like a maniac, her usual restrained manner going out the window in her panic, though it was all a blur to her daughter, curled up in the backseat, wishing she had never done it and dreading what will happen to her next. She had read stories of how trans people were treated in hospitals and psych wards, and part of her wanted to jump out of the car rather than risk any of those stories coming true for her. Her mom continually prodded her for details, trying to figure out why she did it, but she wouldn't budge, afraid of the reaction she would get, for being trans, for being a freak, for being a failure.

The next few hours were a blur. After being hooked up to an IV with an antidote when she lost the contents of her stomach to a repulsive activated charcoal blend, an armed security guard stood by outside her room until a nurse could be set aside to keep constant watch over her. All the while, she was being peppered with questions by her mother and brother once they were allowed into the room, questions increasingly centered around how she wanted her funeral to be handled as they awaited her next bloodwork in spite of what the doctor had said about survival rates.

Aaron wished she could just be left alone, but couldn't bring herself to voice her desire, especially with how worried and stressed her mom was. Sending them out would feel like she was telling them to fuck off and let her die in peace, which part of her

did want, but she already felt terrible enough for getting into this place, the last thing she wanted was to have her mom lose her mind in the waiting area.

When the results came back, a collective sigh of relief spread across the room, and Marlena embraced her child at the good news (though Aaron was not one for hugs at that point). Somehow, she hadn't shed a single tear, being too stressed for anything to happen, but now they flowed freely, thankful that she wasn't about to lose her child who she had been through so much to have to begin with.

When the initial celebration ended, the questions turned back to *why,* and Aaron resumed her defensive stance, refusing to answer or outright lying in response to most of them, insisting she was just depressed and nothing more. She couldn't bring herself to tell the truth, and was determined to keep up the façade, taking the secret to her grave.

After two days of being held in the ER and dealing with the avalanche of questioning and evaluations, having barely eaten the entire time she was there despite the offers from her mom to get something she'd actually enjoy, she was transferred to a psych ward in Westchester county in the middle of the night.

When her mother and brother visited on the first day they were allowed, joined by her father who was off work, she continued to refuse to budge on their questions, hoping they'd just go away and leave her to wallow in her misery. The place wasn't as bad as she had feared, but it was anything but hospitable, and part of her wished she had succeeded just so she didn't end up here.

She did feel like she could be honest with the staff, though, as they didn't seem to be looking for reasons to keep people here long-term, just to get people somewhat stable before their health insurance stopped paying, and then setting them up with their outpatient services to get more money from the insurance companies. The psychiatrist diagnosed her with gender dysphoria and major depressive disorder soon after, and though her parents promised to come back in two days time, a phone call they received prompted them to visit the next day, instead.

Aaron approaches the lounge, confused as to why she has visitors today, and sees her mom looking way happier than yesterday, while her dad seems even more annoyed, if that's possible.

"There's my baby," Marlena says as she approaches Aaron, pulling her into a strong hug. "I knew I was supposed to have a girl. I just wish you had said something sooner."

"Uh, what are you talking about?" she nervously asks.

"The psychiatrist said you're transgender, was he wrong?"

"I… I didn't think he'd tell you that. So much for patient confidentiality," she mumbles, distraught at the revelation to her parents. Of all the ways she had thought about coming out, this one never crossed her mind, but it was definitely up there as one of the worst. *So much for trusting the staff.*

"They probably stuck a form in front of you without explaining it, he said he had written permission to talk to us. But I support you, you will always be my daughter…*our* daughter."

Aaron could tell by the shift in tone that those last couple words were aimed squarely at her dad, and though she was blissfully unaware of the arguments that ensued shortly after her mom got off the phone and on their drive over, she took it as her cue to begin mentally bracing herself, figuring that she was about to get an earful of her dad's politics.

"I still don't believe in this 'gender' rubbish," her dad chimes in with a holier-than-thou tone after they sit down inside the lounge. "I know what the doctors said when you were born, and you've never said anything about being a girl before. If you wanted attention, surely there was a better way to get it." He leans in and continues in a slightly more conspiratorial tone, "I bet it's because you spend too much time online, it's messing with your brain. This psychologist dude probably planted stuff in your head, too."

Aaron just looks down at the table, filled with embarrassment and being unable to respond while her mom's expression morphs from one of love for her child to that of anger as she turns to face her husband. Things had not been great between them as of late, with Marlena suspecting Randor of being less than faithful when he was away for work, but she had decided to put aside her displeasure for these visits, to not fight in front of others and unleash their family troubles for all to hear. But with their argument on the way there, and now this, she couldn't pretend to be alright with it, to let her child get stepped on in her time of need.

“I know our kids far better than you do. She is not faking this, that is an insult,” she declares.

Randor scoffs at her, acting like he was just personally attacked. “Stop trying to take all the credit for raising them, they’re my kids too, you know.”

Aaron buries her head in her hands and tries to minimize her presence as her mother retorts, “Randor, when you’re out putting bread on the table and sleeping around, who stays behind to mow the lawn, cook dinner, do the laundry, go to football games or marching competitions, and just interact with our children? It’s *me*, half the time you’re home you’re still jet lagged. So much about her makes sense now, things that you’ve never seen or heard or weren’t awake enough to give a second thought to.”

“Oh yeah? Like what?” Randor shoots back.

“Well for one thing, she has always preferred to be friends with girls, which is a bit out of the ordinary for boys. Another thing that boys don’t do is want to shave when their first facial hairs come in. They’re always excited about it. Always! Except her, she’s been indifferent at best about it from day one. Ever wondered why you had to get on Adam’s case to shave but she learned on her own since she didn’t feel like waiting for you to get home to teach her?”

“That doesn’t prove anything, I’m sure there are plenty of boys who dislike facial hair.”

As her parents’ argument gets louder and some people halt their conversations to listen in, Aaron wishes she could disappear and teleport into her room, as depressing as it was. It would certainly be better than this, with her parents’ drama getting broadcast to everyone here and probably getting written onto the clipboards of the psych techs, possibly even getting brought up in group therapy. She can already imagine the burnt-out lady looking at the tech’s notes and asking without a hint of emotion, “Can anyone describe a time they have had to deal with adversity in a public space?” *This is all your fault,* she thinks, *you were too much of a wuss to do it right, now your parents are making a scene. Homewrecker*.

“But I’ve taught so many kids, all going through puberty. I can count on one hand — nay, one *finger* — the number of boys who weren’t proud of their first tiny beards, and I’m sure other teachers would say the same. And you’ve never been witness to her talking in a feminine voice.”

“Wait, you heard that?” Aaron nervously asks, briefly showing her tear-streaked face, mortified with the knowledge that if her mom has heard it, her brother most certainly has, too, but never said anything. The first few years, she had only done voice training when she was certain she was alone, but the last couple years she had begun doing it whenever she was in private– or rather, whenever she *thought* she was in private. She had said some embarrassing things in her girl voice (some of them true, others setting out bait to maximize (you)s), and who knows what they had overheard. She may well be an open book at this point.

"I'm sorry you found out like this, but your closet and the shower aren't as sound-proof as you think," Marlena softly replies before shifting her attention back to her husband and returning her voice to its previous volume. "I've heard her sound like a girl so many times, it's kept me up at night wondering. And I even mentioned this to you, but you said I was just overhearing *YouTube videos*!"

"How was I supposed to know if I've never heard him like that?"

"You could've just trusted me. You believed me when I told you how much crap she gets for how she wears her hair despite having never witnessed it yourself, yet somehow *this* is different?"

"Could you two please lower your voices?" a psych tech asks, clearly annoyed that it's the adults who are the ones causing trouble. Across from the lounge, another tech is standing at the nurses' station, likely waiting for a signal to come in and haul someone out. "Other guests are trying to visit, too."

Marlena apologizes to the man before turning back to her husband. "I think you should wait outside if you don't have anything nice to say," she tells him in a low voice.

"I have just as much right to be here as you do," he hisses. "This is my insurance, after all."

The tech lets out an exasperated sigh and asks Aaron what she wants.

"Just mom," she squeaks.

"In that case," the tech says as he turns to Randor, "I'm going to have to ask you to come with me. I'll call security and have them escort you to the waiting area."

"Fine, I'll leave," Randor angrily replies. "But this conversation isn't over."

When the door to the common area shuts, Aaron finally relaxes and gradually returns to a more normal sitting position while wiping her tears away. The tension in the room seems to drain away, and the attention that had been drawn to her parents' argument ceases, with people returning to their previous conversations. Not having eyes on her anymore was a relief, though she was still a bit nervous, unsure how supportive her mom actually was. Part of her worried her mom would only be supportive as far as she could be used as a pawn to wield in arguments with her dad.

"I'm so sorry you have to put up with this. I didn't intend for that to happen, but I couldn't let him insult you like that," Marlena opens, giving a sympathetic look. "Is there another name you would prefer to go by?"

"No, I sorta gave up on figuring that out. Not that I had plans to come out." After a pause, Aaron finally looks up at her mother and asks what she would've been named if she was a girl.

"Honey, you are a girl. And we would've named you Adora."

Part of her wants to respond, "well I certainly don't see a girl when I look in the mirror" or "but what if I'm neither boy nor girl," but she holds back, not wanting to push things. Instead, she thinks about the name for a bit, toying with it in her mind. She had thought about names years ago, reading through probably thousands of names for girls, but couldn't come up with anything that clicked for her and had opted to kick that can down the road. After all, it's not like she was out at that point, and there are girls with her same name and spelling, so she could get by with this name (or a more feminine spelling, like Erin), as much as she disliked it. And that was assuming she ever did come out, which she hadn't really been planning on, having operated on the assumption that she would take her own life before doing that.

But this – *Adora* – clicks immediately.

"I like that name. It feels right."

"Well, you don't have to take that name, I'll call you whatever you want me to."

"I think it fits. What would my middle name have been?"

Marlena smiles at her daughter, happy to have found something comfortable for her already.

"You would've been named after your grandmothers, so some combination of Mary and Ann, but I never had to decide since, well, you know what happened. But we don't have to go by that tradition or figure that out now, I just want to get to know you, the *real* you."

"What do you want to know?"

"How long have you known?"

Adora takes a deep breath and starts to reply "Since—" but is cut off by her mom.

"I want to hear your *real* voice, Adora, not that façade you've had up for so long."

After the small burst of happiness at hearing *Adora,* she takes a bit to process the request, surprised that anyone would call her feminine voice her real one. Until now, she thought that the only other people who had heard it were the anons and trips on /lgbt/ who were giving her advice, at least until a few months ago, when she got far enough along that she started getting replies like "fuck off back to Tumblr" and accusing her of being a cis woman

roleplaying as trans. She had been overjoyed at the responses and had made a few recordings after that before growing bored of the insults she got on /lgbt/.

She had a brief stint roleplaying as a cis woman on /r9k/ and reveled in the (you)s her posts attracted, whether it was just "tits or gfto" or walls of text about how women were a blight on humanity interspersed with hitting on her despite not knowing what she looked like. The novelty wore off fairly quickly, though, and she stopped posting voice recordings soon after, going back to being just another anon on /lgbt/, critiquing others and making bait posts like "not trans, just an hrt femboy," "how do I come out to my parents as a bottom," roleplaying as a repressor, and other nonsense.

As much as she'd like to use her voice elsewhere, until now, it felt too risky. So, to her, it was her girl voice, her *other voice*, the one no one knew, or so she thought. Certainly not her *real voice*.

"Since I was twelve," she finally replies. "But I didn't accept it until I was thirteen."

When her mother finishes absorbing the statement, she looks close to tears. She pulls her heavy chair closer to her daughter's and hugs her, feeling like a terrible parent for not recognizing a child in pain, so much pain for so long that she ended up in this oppressive place, when it might have been prevented if she at least asked about all those odd things she had noticed over the years or hadn't taken Adora's word that she was alright so long ago. If she had thought to say something encouraging back then or gotten her child professional help, this all might have been avoided.

“My poor baby. You’ve been suffering for so long and I should’ve realized it, but why didn’t you say anything?”

“Because I was afraid of how you’d react. And before I figured it out, I didn’t know what I was. I just kept asking myself if I was gay since that was the only way I knew you could be ‘different’ from others.”

“I wish you hadn’t been afraid. I will always love and support you, Adora, no matter what Randor or anyone else says.” After a pause, she asks, “Does this mean you’re into boys now?”

Adora chuckles at the naïve assumption. She had read that exact scenario a few weeks ago in an /mtfg/ thread and figured her mom would be one to ask that but had forgotten about and was caught off guard by it.

“I really don’t know at this point. It’s weird. I think I’m into girls, but I’d rather discuss that some other time, if that’s alright.”

Marlena takes a bit to process it before making the connection that gender is not the same as attraction, and agrees to talk about it later, certainly not in public.

“You know,” she begins when they finally end their hug, “when I was pregnant, I was convinced that I’d have a boy and a girl,

before we even had confirmation about having twins. I don't know why, especially since the first four times I didn't have an inkling about what I was carrying, but I was just absolutely sure of it. It was a huge letdown when the doctor announced that wasn't the case, but it seems I was right all along."

Adora doesn't know what to say to that, and she sits in silence as she processes it. That her mom would be able to predict that, that they were the *fifth* pregnancy…it seems crazy to her, and also incredibly tragic. She had been told that her parents wanted to fill up the house but weren't able to make it happen, but had never been told why, nor had she really thought about it before. If anything, it only made her feel worse about ending up in here considering how much disappointment her parents had to have dealt with prior to her coming into the world, the idea that she might have been about to leave must have broken her mom's heart.

The silence is eventually interrupted when her mother asks if it's alright if she tells the family.

"I honestly don't care as long as no other students at school find out until I've graduated. If people found that out, it would be painting a target on my back."

Marlena nods in agreement. "Given the attention your hair attracted, I can see that. I'll be very careful with who I tell."

A long pause passes between them, and Adora takes in some of the conversations going on around them. Of what she could hear,

some were gossiping about the girl who had been on *Dr. Phil* and who she was trying to start shit with today, a couple were talking about what woke the entire floor up last night, others were discussing family matters, and even though nobody seemed to be mentioning her, she was sure they heard it all.

"So, how are they treating you here?"

"The whole floor is probably going to know that I'm trans by lights out, and I don't know how people will act around me now, but they were alright before. The psychiatrist seems to care about us but has too many patients on his hands. He put me on Lexapro and Wellbutrin for now, though how much of an effect that will have is TBD. Group, however, is a joke; the psychologists leading the sessions seem pretty burnt-out."

Part of her felt like skipping group since it had been completely useless to her so far, but she knew that she had a chance of getting out in less than a week if she seemed cooperative. If this was the break, she might be less inclined to try, but she hated having to make up work for missed days. This place, being so isolated from the outside world, was a bit comforting, but the knowledge that her assignments were piling up always hung over her head.

The regulars didn't seem to care about that at all, but she didn't feel like delaying her graduation, especially since she now had someone on the outside who loved her for who she was. If she was getting disowned, she would probably try to drag out her stay until insurance stopped paying just to have a roof over her head, but now she had something to look forward to, a light at the end of the tunnel.

“Are you feeling any better, then?”

Adora gives a small smile as she says, “A bit, but that was because of you. If the meds are doing anything, I haven’t noticed yet. I was a bit drowsy this morning, but I think that was probably just a coincidence rather than a side effect.”

“I’ve heard those things take a while to really kick in, so I wouldn’t be too worried just yet. So, what is it even like to spend the night in one of these places?”

“The bed, or rather, mattress is pretty crap. No bed frames on this floor, apparently. It’s hard to fall asleep here. Last night I was woken up when some dude tried to run, and I got to see him get booty juiced right outside my room since I’m not allowed to have the door closed.” Adora sighs before continuing, “This place is supposedly one of the better ones outside Manhattan, but I guess the bar for that is pretty low. The regulars say this is one of the better units as well, so I seem to have won a lottery of sorts, if you can believe it.”

“‘Booty juiced’?” her mom asks naively.

“It’s where they inject a tranquilizer or something into your butt. Then they drag you to an isolation room and strap you in until you wake up a few hours later, assuming they don’t decide you’re still a threat and keep holding you there. It was a sight to behold.”

Marlena looks horrified by the description. “I hope you don’t end up in that, it sounds like it would just make you crazier.”

Adora nods in agreement. Being woken up by the footsteps and voices, watching him get tackled and hearing the *thud* as he hit the floor less than ten feet from the doors to the elevators and stairwell (though they probably kept them locked outside visitation hours), and then crying out in pain until the drugs took effect was a nightmare in its own right. Seeing him get dragged away because the techs didn’t feel like carrying him properly to somewhere else on the floor only made it seem even worse.

Falling asleep after that was a challenge, and when she mentioned it at breakfast today, hearing that he got strapped down afterwards only made the whole ordeal worse in her mind. She had heard something similar her first night, but not yet knowing anyone (and it happening on the other wing, out of sight), she hadn’t asked.

“And why aren’t you allowed to have the door closed?”

“Because I’m in here for suicide. No privacy allowed around these parts for anyone who might self-harm, which seems to be most of the floor. They don’t even have locks on the bathroom doors, and *everything* is monitored. Obviously, phone calls are recorded, but the techs are always writing down on their clipboards what we’re doing, who we’re talking to, what they think our mood is…it’s pretty creepy, really, but there’s nothing we can do about it.”

"At least you're still here. A freshman in my homeroom overdosed back when you were in elementary school, and she was in constant pain for a week before she died. I don't know what I'd do if you had succeeded, too," her mom replies, a pained expression on her face as she remembers the incident.

Suddenly, the weight of Adora's actions falls on her like a pile of bricks. Her parents had dropped everything to be there, and her mom was more than willing to accept her the entire time. She might have been right about her dad, but she was lying to herself about her mom for years to try and avoid ever taking a risk and saying anything. All the pain she caused was entirely avoidable. The realization makes her feel like crap, an attention-seeker like her dad was accusing her of being, getting everyone panicked and herself trapped in such an oppressive place for nothing.

"I'm so sorry for putting you through this. I wasn't thinking about anything beyond wanting to die."

Her mom recognizes the distress written across her face and gently holds one of her hands to reassure her, telling her, "It's alright, Adora, you don't need to beat yourself up over it. You're still alive, and that's what matters."

When she calms down, her mother realizes her hair is in a simple three-strand braid with no elastic in sight. "When did you get this done?" her mom asks as she takes it into her hand. She hadn't seen Adora with braided hair before, only ever in that poof or stuffed into a shako during marching band.

"This morning at breakfast. This girl named Glimmer offered since I kept having to brush my hair out of the way, and it's not like I can have anything else holding it in place since that's a self-harm risk somehow."

"I think it looks really cute. Does she know?"

"That I'm trans?" Adora points to a pink-haired lady with her nose in a book a table over and continues, "She's right over there, I think she's probably overheard a lot. I'll talk to her later. She was also the one who introduced me to the lemon Coke that I told you about last time. Seriously, you need to try that stuff, it's *good*."

"Well, I guess I'll have to keep my eyes peeled. Is the food decent?"

"I mean, it's definitely not healthy and not what I'd usually eat, but I'll call this a cheat week," Adora jokes, earning a chuckle from her mom. "Still better than what they serve at school, though I've been told the weekend crew isn't so hot, so I have that to look forward to."

"Enjoy this cheat week while you can, when the family comes over for Christmas it'll be round two for you."

"Oh yeah, I forgot what time of year it was. Time just seems to pass differently when you're so cut off from the world, I guess. Hopefully I'll get out of here quick enough that I don't have to do

make-up exams.” Her expression turns slightly sour as she adds, “Can’t wait to see how the rest of the family acts with this news.” From how her dad loved to talk politics (which inevitably caused family drama that he blamed everyone else for), she had a good idea of the leanings of her relatives. Of course, trans people had never come up before, so all she could go off of was who was homophobic, because if you scratch a homophobe, you almost always reveal a transphobe.

“I hadn’t really thought about that. Would you rather we keep this under wraps until that all is over?”

Adora considers it for a bit before deciding against it. “No, I’d rather just put it out there and let the cards fall where they may. It might get some of them to stay away if they really hate me for it. And you wouldn’t have to worry about what name you use.”

“I can see that. Not to change the subject, but did they give you all the stuff I brought?”

“Not everything. Apparently, those Wonder Woman comics were deemed ‘inappropriate,’” making annoyed air quotes as she says it, “so you’ll want to ask the front desk for them on the way out. Thanks for bringing everything else, the stuff I was wearing was harsher than one-ply toilet paper. And now I have something to do to pass the time besides doodling with crayons.”

Ironically, she had been more social here than she had at school for years, despite it being a much more oppressive environment. But she didn’t have her cell phone, a computer, or anything

beyond the one landline by the nurses' station to connect her to the outside world and distract her, and their phone calls could only be up to five minutes if there was a line at the phone (which there usually was in the evenings). She could probably get mail here, but it wasn't worth mailing anything when her parents were within the local calling area and could visit.

Socialization was the only way to stave off boredom when you didn't feel like reading or coloring. And the people here were real characters, with stories to tell from a surprising variety of backgrounds, far more diverse than her school. Some of them simply were not able to get along with anyone, but most were in a similar situation of trying to find a way to pass the time.

The two continue to talk, and by the time the psych techs walk in, Adora is feeling decent and has a genuine smile on her face for the first time since her Eagle Scout ceremony, and before that, at least a few years. It's the closest she's ever felt with her mom, being able to talk freely (well, as freely as she can in a public space like this) instead of having to heavily filter everything and pretend like she's alright. She had known she was holding back, but hadn't realized just how stifling it felt to be doing that until now, until she could finally be open.

"Alright, evening visitation is now over, please wrap up your conversations," one of the techs announces to the room.

"Adora, I just want you to know how much I love you," Marlena says after they stand up from the table. "It hurts me knowing how

bad things had to get, but just know that I'm not mad or upset with you."

"I love you too, mom," Adora replies, and for the first time in at least a decade, she actually means it. For a long time, she had wondered if the idea of loving a family member (or just unconditional love more generally) was just something that only happened in fiction, some societal ideal that never worked out in practice which people don't want to acknowledge as unrealistic, but now she finally gets it. She finally feels loved in return for who she is, rather than who she was pretending to be, what she was trying (and failing) to live up to.

The feeling is surprisingly liberating, a taste of how things should have been, how they can be, and it gives her some much-needed hope for the future, that things will only get better from here.

"Do you want us to visit tomorrow like we originally planned?"

"I'll have you any days you want to visit. But I'd rather avoid seeing dad for now unless he has a sudden change of heart. And you can tell him that, too. And Adam, I don't want to see him if he treats me like dad."

"I'll let them know, and I'll visit as much as I can," her mom promises. "If you want to make any changes to your birthday or Christmas lists, write them down for me and I'll do what I can."

One of the techs heads towards them after looking down at his watch. “Sorry to interrupt, but you need to leave now, miss.”

Marlena embraces her daughter one last time and tells her that she’ll be back tomorrow.

“I’ll be looking forward to it,” Adora replies honestly. She had been dreading any and all visits from her family before, but now, she means it, already beginning to think of what all she wants to talk about.

Yesterday, with both of her parents and her brother there, she had felt like she was navigating a minefield, afraid of answering their questions in a way that might reveal too much. There had been a lot of awkward pauses as she had looked out the window, pretending to be intensely interested in the leafless trees in the courtyard outside while stalling for time to come up with answers, double-checking them against what she had previously said to ensure she wasn’t about to contradict herself. Now, she didn’t have to worry about any of that.

When the doors to the common area close and her mom disappears from view, Adora turns to her new friend and goes to sit down at her table, not sure what kind of a reaction to expect and a bit nervous. Glimmer didn’t exactly give off straight vibes, but there are plenty of transphobic people who aren’t straight, so all she can do is hope for the best as she pulls out one of the heavy chairs.

“Glimmer?”

The pink-haired lady puts down her book and gives a warm smile. "I heard everything. Good to meet you, Adora. Your mom seems nice."

Chapter End Notes

Lady on the Deck

To: the "man" standing on Union Deck

I see you pacing the top floor,
pretending to get the perfect shot…
A cover for your true intention –
of making this life all for naught.
It's the only reality you have ever known,
the urges going back before the age of nine.
Of pleas and prayers and cries for help,
silently ignored by an apathetic divine.

The regrets you have are beyond enumeration,
but now you put yourself in a perilous situation.
Looking down at the abyss below, you wonder
"Is this really how I want to go?"
But what other options do you have? None,
in the moment, but in the future you will know
the cause of your problems and the inner peace
you have long sought will begin to grow.

You've put yourself in this situation before
and chickened out –
What happens this time?
What if it fails?
Your family standing around you in the hospital,
Wondering how you could put them through it all,
not wondering how you put up with it for so long.

So come on back in, it's been awhile.
(People will be getting suspicious soon.)

Back to the warmth,
back to the office,
back to the sadness.
To live in misery another day,
but not risk the humiliation of a failed foray
into the land beyond.

From:
the woman waiting inside

AO3's chapter editor keeps inserting extra line breaks in between the title and the first line of this poem and I keep having to remove it, so if it looks like excessive spacing, that's why - editor glitch.

E

Chapter Notes

> CW for transphobia and memories of suicidal ideations and childhood trauma.
>
> October 16, 2023 update: I have published a new self-contained short story, *Realizing Adora*, that takes place within this chapter during her return from the psych ward. I would recommend pausing now, reading *Realizing Adora*, and then returning to this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Opening the door to her bedroom when she got back from the psych ward, Adora was greeted by walls that had been repainted a light pink (which was "Touch of Pink" according to the swatch), a new set of sheets on her bed (the comforter and pillowcases of which were also pink), and a box full of new clothes on her bed. Clearly, her mom had been busy while she was away.

The only thing Adora was not entirely satisfied with was the paint – not that she disliked it (it was certainly an improvement over the dark and depressing shade of blue that was previously splashed on her walls, and the spot of blue on the ceiling was gone), she just wished she had been given a heads up since, unlike bedsheets and clothes, paint can't be swapped out on a whim. (Not that she felt like complaining and possibly dampening her mom's enthusiasm.)

While in the psych ward, Adora had made just two additions to her birthday list: an oil painting set (art therapy was way more fun than she had expected) and HRT, the latter of which was something she had wanted since she first started reading about it,

and though she didn't expect it would happen, she figured it couldn't hurt to ask.

After explaining what it was and why she wanted it, her mom's only request was that she first have some sperm frozen "in case you want to have children later" (though Adora was pretty sure she just wanted to maximize her chances of having grandchildren). Randor wasn't very happy about it, but given that Adora was turning 18 and the fact that Marlena was willing to pay out of pocket (or rather, out of their joint bank account) if he tried to pull anything with their insurance, he didn't put up much of a fight.

A week and change after her birthday, she had her appointment. It had gone well, having managed to skip a month of waiting thanks to someone else canceling, and after going over the side effects (which she already knew by heart) and drawing several vials of blood, they sent the prescriptions over. They didn't even wait for the labs to come back.

And more notably for her, unlike every other time she had to have a needle stuck inside her, she didn't tense her muscles, so she wasn't sore afterward. She watched the entire time, too, unlike in the past where she closed her eyes to try and avoid tensing up (which didn't work very well). Perhaps it was the knowledge that this was the beginning of her life turning around, going in a direction she wanted it to, but regardless, she wasn't about to say anything and risk jinxing her next appointment.

When her mom went to pick up groceries after school the next day, Adora would usually walk home, but with her prescriptions having been filled, she made sure to tag along so she could escort

them all the way back to her room, greedily eyeing the labels on the bottles. Two milligrams of estradiol and fifty milligrams of spironolactone, to be taken daily. It took everything in her to not down any on the ride home, or for the rest of the day, but she powered through, determined to make tomorrow a very special day.

The next morning, after eating her breakfast and taking the rest of her medications, she eagerly pops the estradiol into her mouth and does her best to not create any saliva as the pill slowly dissolves under her tongue. She snickers as she remembers what she saw in a bottle marked for her father when she was looking through her parent's medicine cabinet a month ago. He has his stash of little blue pills, and now, so does she.

Her amusement is soon interrupted, however, by her brother popping his head into the room.

"Hey Aaron, have you seen my phone?" he asks. She swivels her chair to face the door, scowling, and flips him off in return. Adam rolls his eyes and replies in an insincere tone, "Oh, my bad. *Adora*, where's my phone?"

She points in the direction of the bathroom, but he doesn't seem to get it, asking again where it is. Eventually, she gives up and writes "YOUR SINK" on a piece of paper and shows it to him, annoyed that he can't understand basic gestures. He was never the brightest bulb, but sometimes it felt like he was playing dumb to mess with her.

"Could've just said it, *dude,*" he chides as he heads to the bathroom.

Adora sighs as she continues dissolving her pill. Her mood is ruined, and there's nothing her mom can say that will convince Adam not to be a dick since he is in agreement with Randor (and physical punishment would not change his attitude). The only saving grace is that he isn't about to out her at school since he doesn't want to be known for having a trans sibling, especially since most of his circle of friends have Confederate flags on their vehicles (despite most of them having no claim to southern heritage whatsoever).

At this point, she prefers Randor to Adam, since at least Randor isn't around half the time, and of the time he is around, a good chunk of it is usually spent adjusting time zones, leaving him not normally in the mood to be shitty to her.

By the time she finishes her shower and heads downstairs, Adora has a smile on her face, and her good morning hug with her mom is extra strong. She rarely hugged her mom before, and according to her, it was always "like hugging a bookshelf," but now Adora actually felt safe being open with her instead of holding up the emotionless, closed-off front she had previously depended on. The increased closeness between the two was obvious even to Randor after a few weeks, who remarked "he's become a momma's boy," kicking off an incredible argument between her parents that made her realize divorce was no longer a matter of *if* but *when*.

“How’s my favorite daughter doing today?” Marlena asks when they part.

“It’s probably just placebo effect at this point, but I feel as though a great weight has been lifted off my shoulders.”

Three months in, Adora wakes one morning to find Rose, the grey and white cat she had picked out when she was young, in her bed next to Swift Wind. Rose looks annoyed at the alarm clock chirping away on the dresser, but happily takes Adora’s heated spot on the bed when she gets up (even though she doesn’t get anywhere near as warm as she used to before starting HRT). Swift Wind had always slept in her bed, but Rose was a much more recent phenomenon.

A couple weeks ago, Rose had started becoming more affectionate, and Adora couldn’t figure out why until she sniffed her trademark red jacket to figure out if it needed to go into the wash. *It doesn’t smell like me,* she realized, or at least, it didn’t smell like what she *thought* she smelled like. After fetching another jacket from the closet which hadn’t been worn in a month and comparing with what smell was left on it, she realized that her scent had changed. Rose was always more affectionate with women, or at least, those who smelled like them, it seemed. The discovery had left her incredibly happy, knowing she passes to a cat. *It’s a start,* she had told herself.

It was also about that time when the fourth chair trumpet, a magicat, began to look at her differently, at first confused, and

then curious. He could tell something was up, but Adora played dumb when he asked, not trusting him enough to consider saying anything (and also not knowing what exactly had changed at the time). She was fairly certain the other hybrids in her classes could tell she was different as well, but none of them ever said anything about it. (Then again, she had spent many hours with her section at afterschool rehearsals and band camp…her other classmates, not so much.)

Alongside her pheromones, the way she processed things changed. Caffeine actually affected her now, and her ADHD medication, methylphenidate, a schedule two stimulant which also happened to be used in the treatment of narcolepsy, became a problem. She was entirely unaware of the nature of her medication until she was trying to figure out why she had become dependent upon melatonin to fall asleep. Her mother had always told her that, if she forgot to take it by noon, to just not take it at all, but didn't understand why until she found a post on reddit that seemed to describe her exact situation. When she tried only taking one 36 mg tablet instead of two, sure enough, she could sleep normally again, and she had her dose cut down.

That your sex hormones could dictate things like this shocked her, and it made her wonder what else was different under the hood.

After trudging over to turn off her alarm, she yawns and looks into her backpack to make sure everything is there. When she finishes, something feels off, and she goes through it a second time to try and figure out what it was. Eventually, she puts her finger on it: her calculus notebook. She hadn't touched it last night. And then it hits her: she forgot to do her homework. "*Shit,*" she mutters as she realizes she'll have to try and finish it during lunch. "*Of course I forgot the homework for my mom's class.*"

As she heads downstairs to have breakfast, it hits her: she was annoyed with herself. *And that's it.*

Her suicidal thoughts had always come in two varieties: passive ones which came and went with no rhyme or reason that she could easily drown out just by reading or listening to music, and active ones, which always arose from something she did or did not do and which were impossible to ignore. She used to measure her days by how many she had – if they came once an hour or less, that was a good day for her (and she did not have many good days).

It was the active thoughts which caused her to down all those pills before, and normally something like this would cause a nonstop barrage of them for at least an hour and regular occurrences for the rest of the day, but now? Not a single one. She was just annoyed with herself, but there were no thoughts of self-harm, and in fact, she can't even remember the last time she had a suicidal thought, so it had to have been at least a month.

The antidepressants she had been put on had only lessened the severity of the thoughts, to the point that she wouldn't cave again. But they still happened. She had been aware that her mood seemed to be steadily improving since staring HRT, especially with her dose increase, but she had written it off as placebo effect, despite having several weeks of incredible happiness as her brain adjusted to her new emotional baseline of "not constantly dead inside and suicidal." She had known it could lessen depression, but never in her wildest dreams could she have imagined it would be entirely gone, and it was only now that she realized just how bad

things were that she considered having any amount of suicidal thoughts "normal."

In the kitchen, Marlena stands by the coffee maker, annoyed that the power had flickered during the night, resetting the clock and consequently making it fail to start her morning brew, instead interfering with her usual morning routine as she had to wait for it to give her the caffeine she depended on instead of it finishing as she awoke. Her attention is soon pulled away from it by the sound of crying, and she goes to investigate, finding her daughter supporting herself on the volute at the bottom of the stairs, sobbing into her arms.

"Adora, what's wrong?" Marlena asks, having not seen her daughter like this in some time.

"I don't want to kill myself," she chokes out, completely catching her mom by surprise, who immediately wonders if she misheard. "I said don't – do not," Adora repeats when she looks up and sees the look on her mom's face.

"I'm not sure I understand," her mom replies, confused about what could be going through her daughter's head. If anything, such an odd statement only made things even worse, and she wondered what could have possibly triggered it.

Adora turns and wraps her mom in a hug as she continues sobbing, trying to find her words.

What even has my life been, she thinks as she recalls old memories from back before she knew about suicide, back when the only way she could imagine ending her suffering was dying while doing something that seemed noble to her, like a firefighter getting trapped and suffocating in a burning building, and all the other fantasies she had about dying in ways that would help others because she couldn't think of any other way to create purpose with her existence. The one time she had outright told her parents she wished she had never been born. The times she had been told to "be a man" and couldn't figure out how or why she would even want to be one. When her suicidal thoughts began to really manifest when she was nine, telling her to jump off of a parking deck or in front of a bus. All the things she couldn't remember since her brain had blocked them out because of the trauma created by simply existing while trans. Of how, after puberty began, things got so much worse for her as her body began going in the exact opposite direction she wanted it to.

"My depression is finally gone, but now I'm realizing just how miserable my life has been," she whines. "So much of it has been centered around my suicidal thoughts, and I hate it. I hate how much of my childhood has been struggling to tread water against the constant tidal wave of depression, how I'm only just now able to be who I want to be, and even then, I can only do it here unless I want to risk getting ridiculed. So much has been taken from me, so much is still out of my control. Why can't I just be allowed to live a normal life?"

Marlena was certainly jolted awake by the statements, but she doesn't have any idea where to begin, trying to process everything that had just spilled out of her daughter's mouth. She ushers Adora over to the couch so they could sit and talk about this further, even though it sounded like her coffee was about to be done. That could wait, she decided, as she had more important things to deal with now. She had failed to recognize her daughter

suffering for so long, the least she could do was lend an ear whenever she wanted to talk.

By the time Adora has finished spilling her heart out to her mom, the freshly brewed coffee has started getting cold. Marlena had assumed the suffering began when her daughter hit her first puberty and was aghast to find out that the earliest memories Adora could accurately place that were indicative of depression were in the second grade, and it likely started even before that, though she only had a handful of memories from before then.

If she hadn't known about this and just known Adora's depression had been ended, it would have felt like something to celebrate, but this knowledge just made her feel like a terrible parent.

She had already felt bad for writing a lot of signs off over the years. Some of them she wrote in the baby book because they caught her off guard, like the conversation Adora had with her grandfather asking why she was going to become a dad and why she couldn't "be like mommy" when she grew up. Others she still remembered vividly, like the time she told Adora that a jacket she wanted was for girls, which only seemed to make her want it more, and she was upset that she couldn't have it because it was "so much better" than the ones for boys (even though, in her mom's opinion, it was objectively worse looking than most of the jackets for boys or girls). And then things she hadn't even known about until now, like the time Adora had tried (and failed) to give herself an orchiectomy when she was nine, well before she even knew what that surgery was, just that she didn't like having testicles because they felt wrong.

But now was not the time to focus too much on the past; her daughter was cheering up from getting a lot off her chest, she still hadn't had her caffeine, and the wake-up call from her daughter would wear off eventually. They could talk more about it later.

Back in the kitchen, Marlena dumps the contents of the pot into her usual thermos, Adora being uninterested as usual, but she almost spills the contents all over the counter when Adora cries out behind her.

"*Fuck,*" Adora gasps as she doubles over in agony, clutching her chest, surprised at how much pain she's in. When she got pummeled on the bus a few years ago, it hadn't hurt half as much as this, and even the time she had gotten a double infection when her wisdom teeth were removed seemed like a walk in the park now.

"What happened? Are you alright?" her mom asks as she puts the pot down and turns around.

"I wasn't paying attention and hit myself with the door," Adora replies as she grabs the milk from the fridge before looking up and trying to hide her pain. "I'll be fine, it just hurt a lot more than I expected."

Marlena thinks for a moment before realizing what could be behind this. *Second puberty, indeed,* she thinks as she asks Adora

if she's been dealing with soreness or pain in her chest before this, to which she nods.

"You know what that means?" she asks, lighting up at getting to share this moment.

"No," Adora replies blankly.

"You'll need to give yourself a wide berth now, because your breasts are growing."

Marlena knew she wouldn't feel so excited over this if Adora was born a girl, but the combination of having finally gotten what she had wanted and seeing her daughter smile as her words set in, her body changing in the right way for once, Marlena can't help but feel proud. Even though her daughter would be off to college before too long, at least they have some time together in which she can impart her own wisdom and see her child blossom into who she was meant to be. And she'd be more than willing to let Adora live here for another year, but Adora didn't feel like dealing with the headache of delaying admission for more than one semester, and neither of them knew who would be keeping the house at this point.

"So, I have a lot more of this to look forward to?" Adora asks, excitement written on her face. If she had thought about it, she would have realized what it was, but she was too focused on her childhood, and then appeasing her growling stomach to think back to everything she had read about the effects of HRT. She was glad that they're finally growing, but is already annoyed with the pain,

and assuming the chart she had seen was accurate, this could last for several years.

Marlena nods her head. “Yep, it sucks, but you’re getting exactly what you wanted. It comes and goes; sometimes they’ll be sore every day, other times it’ll be every few weeks. Welcome to being a woman.”

“You can grow a pair of tits? Last thing I expected to hear this morning, but good luck with that,” Adam calls out as he laces his boots from the foyer, probably going for breakfast with his squad again.

“Yeah, and there’s a lot more changes coming down the pipe, too,” Adora shoots back, holding back her amusement at his crude language.

“Shit, maybe someday you’ll be a woman after all,” he remarks as he grabs his keys and opens the front door. “Almost forgot, I’ll be working closing tonight. I’ll steal a few slices for dinner, don’t bother leaving anything out for me.”

When the door slams shut, the slight tension that hung in the air was released, and the two share a short laugh. He had basically no filter, a fact which relegated him to the kitchen since he racked up a fair few complains when he was temporarily moved to delivering pizzas. If more people were willing to work for his wage, he’d probably have been fired in his first week on the job.

"I think he'll come around," Marlena says as she wipes down what coffee had gotten onto the counter.

Adora nods in agreement. He didn't always deadname her anymore, though whether that was because Randor was a much smaller influence since he had moved out and didn't stop by much or because Adam would have had a change of heart regardless, was something neither of them could answer with any confidence. Randor didn't seem to have changed at all the last time they visited him, though, and Adora had left early since it was obvious who he cared about.

Later that day, Adora got another reminder of the pain she was in for in band class.

With nothing better to do while her director was busy grilling the clarinets on a couple of rough spots, Adora was occupying herself by balancing her trumpet on her leg, seeing how long she could keep it upright by moving her leg around to stop it from falling, along with several other trumpets. It had become a bit of a pastime for them, and she had been dethroned as the champion last week, so she was determined to get her title back. Of course, it wasn't what she was *supposed* to be doing, but whether she had a case of senioritis or was just more inclined to goof off since she wasn't so depressed, she didn't care.

But being the first chair trumpet, Adora's director could see exactly what she was doing, and after watching her for a bit (and

none of the section noticing the quiet in the room), she called out to her, “Aaron, mind reminding us where we are?”

“Huh?” she replies, looking up, followed by a “*shit*” as the instrument falls back and hits her chest, much to the amusement of those beside her. Usually, she’d be a bit embarrassed getting called out, but she’s in too much pain to care about that. It certainly wasn’t as bad as this morning, but then again, her trumpet didn’t weigh as much as an insulated door that had shelves filled with food. The soreness had seemingly gotten worse since the morning, and she had been careful to avoid any more hits, but her luck had run out.

The director gives her an amused look before restating the question, to which Adora sheepishly admits she doesn’t know.

“We’re at measure 104, please pay attention.”

Adora nods her head, and the director turns her attention back to the clarinets. She flicks an eye over occasionally to keep watch over them, figuring at least one of the jokers in the section would be going back to their old ways. Not that she really cared to crack the whip over something like that, but their section leader should have kept a handle on it instead of getting involved in…whatever they were doing. And as expected, it doesn’t take long for the attention of the trumpets to wander.

“What was that about?” the second chair asks. “How could just a little tap here—”

"*Fuck you, Luke,*" Adora grits as he punches one of her breasts, regretting her decision to try and retake her title. "Don't fucking grope me or I'll shove that horn where the sun don't shine."

"You're a dude, you can't be groped there," one of the other trumpets points out after thinking through their section leader's statement.

"But I—" Adora begins, cutting herself off when she realizes finishing her sentence would out herself, opting to let out a sigh of defeat instead. Part of her wonders what would happen if she did come out – after all, what's the worst that could happen? It's not like she was likely to get hate-crimed in this town, but at the same time, she knows there are plenty of homophobes here, and likely even more transphobes.

But even if everybody was fine with it, the last thing she wanted was for people to expect her to start using the women's room, since she didn't want to do that while she still wasn't anywhere close to passing. The last thing she wanted to do was make anyone else uncomfortable with her presence.

She felt it was more likely that some reactionary parents would pressure the school board to pass a rule that trans people had to use the restroom corresponding to the sex they were assigned at birth than acceptance, but she didn't want to be the reason for something like that, either. Better to be invisible and do things nobody noticed like wearing women's clothes (that weren't obviously gendered) than to risk rocking the boat, she figured.

Some of the other trumpets looked interested in how she was going to finish her sentence, but their attention is soon brought back to the podium.

"Just because we're not in marching season doesn't mean I can't make you all take laps," their director announces, annoyed with their behavior. "Now, are you ready to pay attention?"

After class, the director pulls Adora into her office, pointing for her to sit on the old green couch in the windowless room. The last time she was called into this room (as opposed to walking in of her own accord), she was being promoted to section leader after the previous one pushed his luck by intentionally making a substitute teacher and the drum majors angry and acting like they had no authority and was subsequently kicked out of the band, along with his girlfriend (the flute section leader), who had been behaving similarly poorly.

Though she had to take the solo and the people around her had to learn new sets to fill the gap in the middle of the marching season, she had been glad to see those two gone since they had never taken their positions seriously.

Perhaps her time had come now, too. Not that she had royally screwed up like those two, but her actions today certainly weren't in line with her own standards for herself.

“Aaron, what’s going on?” the director opens, sounding more concerned than annoyed.

“Nothing? I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Adora replies with a straight face. She was pretty sure she did know what her director was talking about, of course, but without any explicit confirmation, she wasn’t about to risk giving out anything just yet.

“You’ve been acting differently lately. I’ve known you since freshman year, you’ve always been about being on time, both arriving and leaving as soon as possible and speed-walking everywhere. But now you’re a lot more relaxed in that regard. You also seem to have a different energy about you. You just seem happier, I guess? It rubs off on the rest of the section, too. The vibe I’ve gotten from their playing has changed. You definitely talk more, too, for better and, perhaps, for worse.”

The blonde continues to keep her mouth shut, so her director continues, “I know it’s not my business, but after you spent time in the hospital last semester, it seemed like something had changed. I can hear most everything people say from my podium, even when they think they’re being discreet, and I overheard your little conversation. There have also been a couple rumors among some of the faculty that your mother has denied, and I’m not sure if you’re aware of them, but the point is that I’m not the only one who’s noticed you act a bit different now.”

“Yes, I am aware of them,” Adora reluctantly replies.

The last thing she had expected was for the teachers to be more cliquish and backstabbing than the students, but according to her mom, it was like a high school drama film at times with some of them. But they kept their gossip outside the classroom, leaving the students blissfully unaware of the clown fiesta that went on behind the scenes.

Supposedly, it was limited to each other rather than involving the students, but they seem to make exceptions for the children of staff, which she found out when the flute section got new leadership. Having a line-in when the senior-most guidance counselor's daughter got booted from band was amazing, one of the biggest gossips in the school being unable to handle the spotlight being put on her for once and lining up a job at another school for the next fall, but for Adora, it also meant there were comments about her circulating, and downright nasty ones at that.

"I am not bipolar, that's ridiculous, and quite frankly, insulting to people who have to deal with it. And I don't know if I'm gay or what, right now I'm not into anyone. The truth is much worse than either of those," she mutters.

"Well, I'll still listen to whatever's on your mind. I can keep secrets."

The bell rings, and the sounds of people escaping to the freedom of the outside world fill the room. She knows her director is a trustworthy person, but she's never been holding a secret like this before. Unsure what to do, she decides to step out for a bit and figure things out. She didn't have to say anything, after all, she

could just leave if she wanted. Knowing there's an out reassures her, and she decides to take her leave.

"Can I go to my locker first?"

"Do whatever you want, you don't have to talk unless you want to. You're not in trouble. Well, you could be if what happened today starts repeating itself, but as long as you keep some control over them in the future, you're cleared on that front."

"Thanks, Mara," she replies as she grabs her bag, partially relieved.

On the walk back from her locker, Adora stops in the middle of a crowded hallway, feeling people bump into her trying to head out for the day. She had been racked with indecision on her way up, and now she could barely move. Ahead lay the band room, to the right her mom's room, and behind her, the bus lot and the road home. Freedom. Both from having to tell Mara and from talking to her mom about how her day had gone, even though her mom would probably reassure her she made the right choice regardless.

When the crowd thins, she turns to the right and heads to her mom's room but pauses in front of some lockers just outside it. *What am I so afraid of?* she thinks. Mara wouldn't out her (or at least, she didn't think she would). To her knowledge, the only

other person at the school who knew Mara was married was the principal since she had to ask how to add a dependent to her health insurance (if she had asked the front office staff, it would've been common knowledge by the end of the day).

Not that she needed to keep her relationship a secret at this point (she certainly didn't have to worry about getting fired for it anymore unless the school wanted a lawsuit), but she preferred to keep her involvement with the drama mill to be that of a spectator, and the revelation of a multi-decade relationship would shine a spotlight on her.

Clearly, Mara trusted her, enough to tell her something that not even the drum majors knew. Revealing that she was trans would be mutually assured destruction…or not, because she didn't have the courage to reveal something like that, even in retaliation. She wasn't going to feed the drama mill just because her trust was violated, and whether that was a bad thing or a good thing, she didn't know.

And it could be that someone overhears them rather than Mara saying anything, especially without the chatter of students to muddle things. The walls certainly weren't as thin as the older wings of the school, but any human who put their ear to the door could listen in on a conversation at a normal volume.

She'd certainly lose friends if that happened.

Did she *really* have friends here, though? She always kept people at a distance, afraid of showing them the true version of herself.

Really, the only person who she was close to (besides her mom), who she would consider an actual friend, was Glimmer, and that was purely because she got outed by her parents' argument and they stayed in touch after leaving the psych ward. Everyone else, on the other hand, she remained afraid of their judgment and kept them at an arm's length, even her two closest "friends" whom she had known since kindergarten.

She didn't know of any other trans people at this school, so just existing felt like she was playing with fire, and telling anyone felt like she might be about to dump a gallon of gasoline onto it. The school had no official policies on how trans students should be treated, everything was written from a cisnormative and heteronormative perspective.

It felt like she was suffocating from always having to box up and hide away such a large part of herself, even if it was for her own safety.

Could she keep living in the closet to everyone else? Yes, but it just kept getting harder and harder to do that. It was difficult mentally, feeling so alone in a school with over a thousand students, but also because of the small near misses that could easily out her, like when she forgot to strip off her nail polish before coming to school and had to pass it off as having lost a bet, or her comments in band today. She wished she didn't have any of this to worry about. She wished she could just be herself, or better yet, be a cis woman. Then she wouldn't have to worry about being accepted by others, or at least, she wouldn't have to worry about being accepted and viewed as a woman.

Eventually, she decides her director is trustworthy enough. And she can record their conversation in case the record needs to be corrected later on. Telling just one person might help, she reasons. She doesn't have to tell anyone else. If it gets out, it'll suck, but it's a risk she feels ready to take. Even if Mara is transphobic, it's her last semester here, and she could drop the class since she had already met graduation requirements, so she wouldn't be stuck in a class with a hostile teacher. It would be an incredibly rude thing to do, but it would be a way she could retaliate that she wouldn't feel horrendous about like she would outing her director.

After starting a new recording on her phone, she begins mentally preparing for the worst as she heads to the band room. It's fifteen past the bell now, but her director is still in the office, working on a crossword puzzle.

"*Six letters…chocolate treat…starts with 'B'…*," Mara mutters while tapping her pen against the desk before noticing the new occupant in the door and waving her in.

Adora thinks through the hint she heard as she sits down, and soon remembers the name of a character in her favorite show.

"Bonbon?"

Mara looks at the puzzle for a bit before smiling as she writes it in and looks over to her student. "I can't believe I missed that one. So, what's on your mind?"

The small smidgen of confidence she had disappears and Adora clams back up as she remembers what she's here for. The band room was empty when she came in, so the chance of anyone putting their ear to the door was negligible, but it did little to ease her fears of rejection, or worse. Part of her wants to walk out now, but she knows she'll be left wondering *what if?* if she does that.

"I need this to stay completely confidential," she says, her nervousness obvious in her voice.

Her director gives a reassuring nod as she replies, "I can do that. Assuming that nothing falls under mandatory reporting requirements, of course."

"Mara, I—" is all Adora can get out before a frog in her throat shuts her up. "I—" she tries to begin again, only to smack right into the same mental roadblock. *Why did I think I could do this?* she thinks as tears form in her eyes and she buries her face in her hands. *Why did I have to be trans? Why me? Why can't I just be normal?*

Prior to her suicide attempt, the last time she had cried was the night she fully came out to herself. But since starting HRT, her emotions had been all over the place. Before, she was basically the definition of stoic, but now, cute pictures of animals were enough to make her cry, and when she was down in the dumps, it took a lot to hold back her tears. It was something she has previously looked down on a couple of her classmates for, but now she knew just how embarrassing it could be and how difficult it

was to control. Mara had certainly never seen Adora cry before, and she started getting up to move over to the couch, only to be waved back to her desk chair.

"Take all the time you need," her director replies as she hands over a box of tissues, which Adora gladly accepts. She looks back to her crossword puzzle to prevent herself from staring, but she can barely think of anything, wondering what could be so powerful that it would bring her student to tears like this. Like her, Marlena never got very close to any of her coworkers because of how some of them acted, so whether there was a death in the family, divorce, or anything else, she hadn't the slightest idea.

Each minute that passes feels like an ice age, and eventually, Adora gives up on trying to use words, instead fishing the discharge papers from the psych ward she had shown at her HRT appointment and handing them over before burying her face in her hands. The papers had gotten plenty of wear around the edges from never having been removed from the backpack and getting squashed by textbooks on numerous occasions, and Mara has to rub the sheets against the edge of her desk to get the largest folds out.

After being told she could read through the whole thing, she begins reading from the top. Below the legal name field, she spots, "*Preferred name: Adora,*" and she does a double take before continuing on, now having a good idea what to expect.

She skips down to the admission notes and lets out a single "Oh" before silencing herself to avoid making Adora any more worried. She had thought that Marlena's explanation for why Adora was in the hospital seemed a bit less than truthful, and it seems her

suspicions were correct, but seeing where her student actually went and what led up to it, she can't help but feel guilty, like she should have noticed something, especially since she considered Adora a friend with all the times she popped into the office to hang out.

Mara hands the papers back, not wanting to read on further, and offers a hug, which is immediately accepted.

Adora had thought the faucet had run dry, but when her director asks which name and pronouns she'd prefer, the rivers start flowing once again.

"Adora, but only in private," she chokes, her mood having shifted from fear to joy at not being rejected by her favorite teacher. "And she/her is good, but not around other people."

"Well, Adora, I support you," her director reassures. "I'm sorry you had to go through this. It might feel like you're all alone, but trust me, there's a lot of trans people out there. I've had several in my circle of friends since before you were born, and I could introduce you to some of them if you want. And I'm sure there's at least a couple trans people at this school, just judging by the recent growth we've had."

When Adora finally ends the hug, a giant smile is stretched across her face. "Thank you, Mara," she says softly. "I'll think about it. But in any case, if it's alright, I don't like talking like this." She switches into her girl voice and continues, "This is the voice I use

at home, and as long as nobody's around to overhear, it's the one I'd prefer to use with you. If that's alright, anyway."

The voice catches Mara off guard, and her surprise was written across her face. "Of course it's alright. And that is impressive, your voice is really good. I take it that your family is supportive?"

Adora sighs. She no longer felt guilty for the state of her parents, but she couldn't help wishing that she hadn't been the straw to break the camel's back. No matter how many times her mom reassured her it was inevitable, she couldn't shake the thought that if she hadn't attempted, her parents wouldn't be in this state. "My mom certainly is, but my dad really isn't, and I'm pretty sure they're going to be filing for divorce before the end of the semester. Things have gotten…strained between them, to put it lightly. My brother might be coming around, but it's hard to tell. The rest of the family is a real mixed bag, some are downright vile about it."

"Well, I'm glad you have someone on your side. I'm also glad you felt comfortable enough to share this. I always figured you were some kind of special, but I wasn't about to say anything. If you don't mind me asking, what exactly happened between you and Luke today? I didn't see what happened, but I did overhear it."

Adora takes a deep breath, a bit embarrassed for what she's about to say. Part of her doesn't want to say anything, even though Mara wouldn't be mad at her. Being the victim isn't what she wanted, she just wanted to exist without this stuff happening to her.

"So…" she begins, fighting the temptation to look down at the floor and ramble on in an absurd level of detail, "I've been taking estrogen for around three months, and, well, there have been some *changes*, and where he punched me was a bit… *sore*… and it hurt."

"Oh, that explains a lot," Mara remarks as she replays what she saw when Adora was messing around with her trumpet and the later incident. "I need to check something."

Mara sits back down at her desk and goes through a drawer until she pulls out a handbook, which she begins rifling through before reading over a couple of pages. Eventually, she lets out a sigh as she closes it back up and puts it away.

"As much as I'd like to write him up for that, school policy seems to be that men cannot have their breasts touched in a sexually inappropriate way. I have reason to believe our principal is an ally, and if you were to come out and it happened again, I could make sure something like that receives an appropriate response, but otherwise…"

"No, I don't want to deal with that. I don't really have any plans on coming out here at this point, and I doubt that'll happen again."

Adora's phone buzzes, and she checks it to find a message from her mom, asking if she's riding back with her. Part of her wants to stay and talk more with her director with such a large weight lifted from her shoulders, to talk about what happened back in

December, how long she’s known, the process of coming out to herself, her family, the abyss she sunk to, the effects of HRT so far, and a hundred other things, but it’s supposed to rain tonight, and she doesn’t feel like pushing her luck by walking home. She sends a quick reply and turns back to face her director.

“There’s a lot I want to say, but I should be heading out. I’d like to stop by tomorrow after class, if that’s alright.”

“Of course, Adora, my door is always open. And you have my number if you need to reach me outside this building. Is there anything you need from me?”

“Can I have another hug?”

“Absolutely.”

Chapter End Notes

> Turns out there is a grain of truth to the belief that men can handle alcohol better than women. Sex hormones affect the way your body metabolizes substances, and the way testosterone changes things actually boosts your tolerance. Basically every trans woman I know who transitioned after knowing their boundaries with alcohol reports that they became a lightweight. And that goes in reverse for trans guys: they can drink more before becoming tipsy.
>
> (That said, it's just a grain of truth. Your metabolism is what it is; sex hormones are not the end-all-be-all for tolerance or there would be no light-weight men and all women would get drunk after two beers.)

Shoutout to my second band director in high school for being a great person.

There was a trans guy in the mellos/French horns (who transferred to our school after he had to move in with his grandparents) and our director always kept watch in the men's locker rooms to make sure nobody ever tried to start anything with him.

(Our first director would never have done that. He didn't even let any guys join the color guard.)

Girl for a Day

Chapter Notes

Aka the creative writing chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was a rainy Thursday afternoon, and after hanging out in her band director's office for a bit after school, Adora went to her mother's classroom like usual. In the past, it was rare that she would ride home with her mom (usually walking home unless it was raining), but now, she almost always headed over to talk and get started on her homework before going home. Her becoming a staple of her mom's classroom in the afternoons did not go unnoticed, of course, and it only seemed to add to the stupid rumors that got made up about her.

The closest anyone had gotten to the truth was the idea that she had came out as being gay. She still didn't know who she was attracted to, but the coming out part was accurate. Part of her wanted to find whoever was behind the rumors and tell them off, but that would probably only make it worse amongst the cliquish few responsible for most of the teacher gossip, especially since they seemed to have grown bored of speculating about her. Her classmates, by comparison, had barely paid any attention to her before, and the trend had continued uninterrupted.

Being situated at the end of the hall, it was easy to keep a lookout for anyone who might be within earshot after the teachers around Marlena locked their doors and headed out for the day, and so far, the hallway had been empty enough that you might expect a tumbleweed to blow through. Rainy days always seemed to make the stragglers clear out quicker. And with the area quiet enough to

hear a pin drop, after finishing an online training course on mandatory reporting laws, Marlena called Adora over to her desk.

"Adora, come check this out. I think you're gonna love it!"

Adora gets to a stopping point and heads over, wondering what this could be about.

"You're never going to guess what they have planned for spirit week!"

She shrugs her shoulders. "Hat day?" she asks, uninterested. She had never really bothered participating in anything during spirit weeks (besides hat day) since she didn't really care all that much. She certainly cared about football, but when you're required to attend every game because you're in marching band, you have nothing better to occupy your time for the evening. Their little chants and the bits they played for first downs and third downs in addition to the usual repertoire of pep tunes made the games a lot more exciting, especially since their team had only marginally improved from losing every game in her freshman year.

That she wouldn't be able to do marching band again since the college she was going to didn't have a football team made last fall much more special for her, soaking up every cadence, putting everything into each show, and pushing her section to give it their all after she took over to make the most of it, a case of reverse-senioritis. She had doubled her collection of buttons, being much less picky with what she bought when she went to marching competitions, and though her decoration of the hat she wore

outside during practice had earned her the nickname “Buttons” in her freshman year, it had become her primary form of address by her section during the marching season as she covered every inch with terrible puns and in-jokes.

Meeting Glimmer and becoming really good friends with her had made her realize something rather depressing: the people who she previously considered her close friends were more like acquaintances. Band had been her lifeline for social interaction the past four years, but the “friends” she had there were more friends by sheer exposure than anything else, and if they had met in any other class, they would never have been anything but classmates.

If you’re with a group of people for several weeks in the hot summer sun during band camp, Tuesday and Thursday afternoons at practice, Friday nights for football games, and Saturdays for competitions, you develop a lot of in-jokes and camaraderie that make it feel like you’re a lot closer than you may actually be. It had probably been the only thing preventing her from falling into a deep depressive spiral before, but the “friendships” she had were incredibly flimsy when she actually thought about it in the context of now knowing what a close friend actually is.

That’s not to say she would have not taken band if she were to do high school all over again – she loved playing for crowds, being a part of such a large group, and seeing things come together after all that time practicing. (The fact that their uniforms were the same for men and women was also quite nice.) It was a great distraction that helped reduce the time she spent rotting her brain on 4chan, and had helped her feel a lot less alone, and that was worth its weight in gold to her.

There were really only two things at her school that she really cared about: the football team and the band. She kinda cared about her programming class, but she was way ahead of everyone else, so it was mostly an opportunity for her to relax and do homework in the mornings. So, spirit week stuff generally didn't interest her, though she did always wear her trademark button-covered hat on hat day.

"I meant besides that, that's low-hanging fruit. Check out this email, it's going to be announced on Monday."

Adora bends over to view the monitor and she sees the usual assortment, but instead of Wednesday being twin day, it's "crossdressing day," with the subtitle "dress up as the opposite sex." It makes her recoil slightly, disgusted at the implication. She had only done it once, and it had left her deeply ashamed, and the label immediately brings back the awful memories, even though her mom didn't care when she owned up to it. Her dad had called her one once, and it had solidified her thoughts on the term and lowered her opinion of him even more. That they would put this on the list was a complete surprise to her, almost like she was being singled out, though she knew that wasn't the case.

"I am *not* a crossdresser," she grits.

"I know, I just thought you could dress the way you want for once," her mom replies, a bit sheepish for the implication when she remembered how much shame her daughter had with the term and realizing it might make her dysphoric to think about. "It's not for almost two weeks, so you can take your time deciding and we can pick up a fun outfit if you want, or you can just wear what you always do."

“I’ll think about it,” Adora replies as she heads back to her seat to continue her work, adding “but doing this will probably generate more rumors about me.”

“I know, but this is up to you. I’ll continue to deny whatever crap they come up with. I just want you to be happy.”

By the time they got home, Adora had made up her mind: she was going to go all out. Even if people reacted poorly to it, she had less than a month before school was over, and she could handle it. Her mom was enthralled, and they went shopping that weekend for an outfit. Though Adora didn’t pass, it didn’t matter since, like when her mom took her to Sephora, the sales reps just cared about making their commission and were more than willing to put on a smile for anyone who wanted to buy women’s shoes (especially since Marlena was also buying a couple pairs for herself).

The prospect of dress shopping, however, had Adora worried since that would require going into a changing room, but when they stopped to pick up some clothes that had been altered, Marlena’s seamstress (who knew about Adora and was fine with her) pulled a beautiful dress off the rack that had been abandoned by the person who dropped it off. There was also a gorgeous sleeveless red dress that had caught her eye, but it seemed too formal, while the first one was about the level of formality that she saw amongst the girls who did sometimes wear dresses to school.

That either would be abandoned was surprising considering they appeared to be custom made, with a higher construction quality than most of what was brought to the shop, but they fit, and after Adora had her measurements taken for alterations, the only thing left to think about were small accessories.

Having been on HRT for less than five months, she was on the shores of the ocean of androgyny at best, and with what she had learned about makeup from her mom thus far, she could make herself look a bit feminine on a good day. But although she had certainly improved, she still wasn't very good at it, leading to a lot of confused looks and staring as people tried to figure out if she was a boy or a girl, much to her dismay. But her mom was the daughter of a professional makeup artist and kept her skills sharp by helping out at various events, and with her doing the makeup and working her magic, nobody would think twice about Adora's gender. As much as she wasn't a fan of makeup (or rather, having to use it in order to pass), she enjoyed being a little canvas, especially since her mom loved doing this.

Previously, Marlena had always done her experimenting on herself to figure out what would work best, but now she had a willing test subject she could call upon. For Adora, there was something relaxing about sitting down on a stool in the master bathroom and letting her mom go to work, and the way she talked through the process always set her at ease as the brushes danced across her face. But today, the focus was her, rather than some character for a production that may not even have a speaking role, and she got up early for this. Although her mom had created the same natural look plenty of times before to teach her, she couldn't help but smile as her mom contoured and highlighted her face perfectly.

“All done,” Marlena announces after applying the setting spray. “You should blot your lips before lunch and be prepared to reapply after, but other than that, you should be all set for the day. Now, let’s get you all dressed up.”

Adora had gotten a strapless light blue dress with a floral pattern and an off-white cardigan to ensure she wouldn’t be violating the dress code. For her feet, she chose a pair of white pointy toe pumps. They had taken her a whole week to learn to walk properly in, having not worn anything higher than a pair of hiking boots before, but she could easily take on stairs with them now, and even walk at a brisk pace in them.

The heel was just under a couple inches and wasn’t super slim, but the process of getting used to them gave her a lot of respect for those who wore shoes like these to work every day. It also reminded her of a memory from when she was younger, where she had seen a woman take off her platforms and run across a parking lot to catch a train. It had boggled her mind at the time, but now, she understood that perfectly.

Her mother helped her zip up the dress and tie a white silk scarf around her neck in a French style. Adora put in her small golden hoop earrings, and her mother removed her hair clips and went to work on a French braid. Her pastel pink nails still looked fantastic from last night, so they left them untouched. Painting her nails was a lot more fun than she had imagined it would be, especially since she could hold her hand perfectly still and do little designs on them (though she just did a solid coat for today).

Because she always wore closed-toe shoes to school, her toenails had been a rainbow for the past week, but she usually only did

her fingernails on Friday nights since she would have a couple days before she had to take it off. The time to make them look good usually wasn't worth spending if she had school the next day, but this was an exception.

"Well, what do you think?" Marlena asks after finishing with her daughter's hair, incredibly proud of her work and the transformation she's pulled off, and also proud of her daughter.

"It looks amazing," Adora whispers, angling another mirror to see more of her head and taking in as much as she can. She twirls around in the dress and watches with glee as the skirt rises slightly and follows her. When she goes to the floor-length mirror in her mom's closet, seeing everything from the shoes to her hair fills her with joy. It's what she has always wanted to see looking back at her in the mirror, and she fights back her tears, afraid the setting spray would fail and cause her makeup to run.

"I think so too, honey. That's something I'd put on our Christmas cards. Let's get a second opinion."

When Adam walks in, he stares for what feels like an ice age, as if doubting that Adora could actually look like that. He had known the two were planning something, but hadn't seen the dress before, nor did he realize just how good his mom was with makeup. He had certainly known Adora had a pair of heels from seeing her wearing them around the house to get used to them (and hearing them clomp around on the hardwood floors, even with some pads to reduce the volume) and had seen her with braided hair a fair amount, but all of this was something else.

“Well, what do you think?” Adora eventually asks.

“You look more like a woman than mom,” he mutters before heading back to the kitchen.

The words turn her mood back up to eleven, and she turns and hugs her mom tightly, so happy about how well it’s turning out so far. She had hopes for how things would go, but had kept her expectations low to avoid disappointment. But even the wildest dreams she had were nothing compared to how she feels so far.

After taking pictures, the two head off to school, Adora getting both more nervous and excited with each passing minute, wondering how the rest of the day would go. She wasn’t sure if she would rather pass and be recognized or appear like a complete stranger, but in any case, she had no idea which way things would go. Part of her wished her dad was there to see this, but another part figured nothing good would come of that.

When they parted ways, she could tell there were guys checking her out. One even tried to hit on her when she was at her locker (to which she acted uninterested, rather than admit who she was). Not that she minded (at least, beyond the initial discomfort); this was pretty much the reaction she was hoping for as she walked with all the confidence she could muster to her first class. Perhaps she was a bit dressed up relative to the student body, but given what some of the girls occasionally wore, she looked like one of them, dressed up for some event afterschool.

She probably could have worn her usual clothes and still passed with her mom's help, but going out in an outfit that screamed *woman* rather than "could go either way" was much more fun. It was also a bit exciting because it was more daring – if she dressed like she normally did, she could just strip off her makeup, put her hair back in its usual poof, and go about her day, even though her nail paint can't be easily washed off in the sink. But this outfit provided no such escape route. Technically she could still strip off her makeup and be just Aaron again, but if she's going to be going to be thought of as a crossdresser today, she would much rather be thought of as a convincing one.

Most of the guys who participated treated it as a joke, doing thinly veiled misogynistic tropes like "hah, I'm wearing leggings and have a Starbucks cup, so basic amirite?" A few went out in drag (which surprised her), but by and large, it's pure laziness amongst those who did something.

When she enters her programming class, she is greeted by a wolf whistle that ends all the other conversations in the room and draws their eyes to her. The callout, which she had heard plenty of times before towards other women, is way more embarrassing than she had ever expected it could be, and though catcalling didn't sit right with her to begin with, it hits her just how utterly disgusting it is, her body becoming a matter of public debate by people she had no interest in. But given that she wasn't sure who did it (or if it was from someone in the room instead of the hallway behind her), she wasn't going to make a scene, and she grits her teeth and acts like nothing happened as she goes to her seat.

When she sits down at her desk, her teacher questions why she's even there since she isn't one of her students.

“I can assure you that I am,” she replies in the low voice she uses exclusively at school now, her face incredibly smug. “I’m surprised none of you recognize me.”

“Aaron?” one of her classmates says in a similar state of disbelief to Adam an hour ago, himself sporting the “basic white girl” outfit. “What the fuck, you *actually* look like a girl.”

“That’s the idea. My mom helped me a lot with pulling this off. Seems like I’m the only one in the room who took this seriously.”

“If I didn’t know any better, I’d probably try to get your number.”

Amused, Adora breaks out her girl voice and responds, “Oh, so I’m a pretty girl?” She can’t help but tease, enjoying the validation, even if it is a bit backhanded.

He stares at her, mouth agape, and another classmate questions how she did that.

“Do what?” she asks back in her low voice, playing dumb.

As much as she would like to use her girl voice all day to complete the effect, that’s a line she can’t bring herself to cross. That her mom was really good with makeup was incidental, something

which didn’t require her to do anything but decide she wanted to participate (ignoring the fact that she wouldn’t be sharing her mom’s makeup since that was disgusting even if they had the same skin and could use the same items to begin with); if she used her girl voice more than a handful of times, it would be obvious she had been practicing for some time, and even though there was less than a month left until graduation, she would rather keep the scrutiny generated by this little stunt to a minimum.

“That thing with your voice!”

“Oh, that,” she says innocently before lying through her teeth, “I just shot for the moon and got lucky. I didn’t think I’d actually sound like a human being, much less a woman.”

Nobody cares to try and challenge her, and after the initial shock wears off, some of the conversations in the room return, but a few people continue to stare at her for some time, especially as the stragglers trickle in before the bell and take in a complete stranger sitting in Aaron’s seat, only to be told by others that the mystery woman is, in fact, Aaron. It’s a bit annoying having to sit around, being gendered correctly but then having to let everyone deadname and misgender her, but it’s the best she can manage, and it’s only for today. Besides, the validation she received earlier was more than worth it.

The pattern of surprise and disbelief continued in her other classes, and with it, the cycle of gender euphoria and dysphoria as

she received validation followed by deadnaming and misgendering as people found out who she was. She wasn't pulling anything with her voice after her first class, not wanting to make it common knowledge that she had a girl voice.

At lunch, when she went to use the restroom, the gym teacher monitoring the hallway calls out to her with a mouth full of food, "Excuse me, miss."

Adora looks up from her phone and turns around, unsure what she's being called out for.

"That's the wrong bathroom, you know."

She had considered the possibility that she would have to use the bathroom before band (where they had single occupant restrooms she could use without issue), but hadn't been planning on taking things that far, figuring she would just use the men's room if push came to shove. But given the fact that a teacher is telling her to use the women's restroom, she has no reason not to.

Technically it's not an order, but judging by the tone of voice being used, there definitely will be consequences if she were to go into the men's, and if she were to try and say she was just dressing up, she didn't want to find out what kind of a reaction she would get. And as she thought about it, she realized that using the women's room is exactly what she wants to do.

“Oh, thanks, I was a bit distracted,” she replies in her girl voice.

The teacher rolls her eyes, muttering that they should’ve never lifted the cellphone ban before going back to her lunch as Adora turns and heads into the women’s restroom. As she walks in, she can feel herself getting nervous. All day, she had been a bit on edge because this was quite daring for her, and this seemed to be the logical conclusion of it, the most daring she would be unless she decided to out herself.

Thankfully, the room is empty, and even though the locks on the stalls are all broken (likely not repaired on purpose with how often people got busted smoking in here), wearing a dress means she has a fair amount of fabric draping over her legs, hiding her genitals from anyone who might accidentally (or not so accidentally) open the stall door.

The room is surprisingly similar to the men’s room directly opposite this one, except in place of the urinals there are two more stalls, there’s a tampon dispenser, and the stalls all have a small trash can inside them (though she would never need them for their intended purpose). Not that she would have expected a radical departure from what she was used to seeing, but she had never thought about how it would look different, either. The only other difference was that the paper towel dispenser to the left of the sinks was in better condition, though whether that was due to age or roughhousing, she had no idea.

One of the stalls had blood on the seat (which was certainly a first for her), but the others appeared far cleaner than the men’s room at first glance. Even the floor wasn’t as sticky (though it certainly wasn’t perfect). It felt right to be in here, but it also made her

incredibly nervous that someone would walk in and recognize her or somehow just know what she was. If any hybrids came in, they probably wouldn't be able to tell anything was up considering her pheromones had changed, but if anyone from her previous classes stepped in…

"You can do this, Adora," she quietly tells herself, taking a few deep breaths to calm herself enough to use the bathroom. Despite her dress, if she was in the men's room, it would've taken half the time since she wouldn't have so many nerves to get over. It takes almost a minute before she's actually able to go. She hadn't used a urinal in years (feeling too uncomfortable to stand while peeing), yet being in a different room, one she hadn't been in before, was enough to make it just as difficult. In the distance, the noise of the cafeteria occasionally rises and falls as the doors open and close.

She remains the room's only occupant until she starts washing her hands, when another girl strolls in. She can feel the hairs she missed when she shaved last night standing on end, nervous that she was going to get found out and humiliated, but soon found that her fear was entirely misplaced.

"That's a nice dress."

"Thanks, this thing's even got some pockets," Adora replies as she pulls out her lipstick and makeup remover wipes.

The girl studies the dress (and possibly Adora) for a bit before asking where she got it from. The question helps to calm her

nerves, that she doesn't seem to be the target of an inquisition by self-appointed bathroom police. She knew that her fears were mostly illogical, except that one of her classmates from earlier might walk in (and she had never seen this girl before), but all that would really assuage them was being proven wrong, as one of her fears was just now.

"My mom's tailor," she replies while stripping off the lipstick. "Someone didn't want to pay for their alterations, so it was put up for sale. The tags were gone, so I've got no idea where or when it was originally from, but it might have been custom made."

"Wish I could get one of those," the girl wistfully replies before heading into a stall.

And just like that, her nervousness almost completely disappears. Something that she knew but hadn't realized before was that she never paid close attention to who used what bathroom, never considered being the bathroom police. She had seen plenty of women use the men's room before, even without a line out the door.

Most people just don't pay attention as you're not being weird, and since her voice and face passes there's a decent chance that, even if she was recognized, nobody would care enough to say anything. Her mom had told her that most people are too busy worrying about what others are thinking of themselves to take a critical eye to those around them, but she never truly believed it until now.

By the time she's finished reapplying her lipstick and blotting her lips, two more girls have dropped in, neither of them giving a second glance, being deep in conversation and immediately ducking into the stalls. Another first for her: hearing people do anything beyond a simple "hey" to acknowledge each other's presence in the bathroom. She almost wondered if they were there just to socialize in private at first (or light up), but it soon became apparent that the rules of socialization in the women's room were very different than the men's.

When she finishes touching herself up, she returns to the cafeteria, relieved and incredibly happy. The emotional high of using the right bathroom without anyone questioning her lasted well into the afternoon, the knowledge that she had finally *done that* constantly dancing in her mind.

By the time the final bell rang, she had only noticed a handful of other people taking the day's theme seriously. However, she certainly didn't see or know the entire school population, so there could easily be more, in addition to those who may blend in like she did. Mara had even pulled her into her office at the start of class, thinking she caught someone trying to steal a trumpet, only to be surprised when she recognized the mystery student's voice.

Adora had told her director she was going to do something today, but had opted to keep her plans a surprise. Mara loved the look (and was very proud of her for going through with it), and Adora spent her time after class in her director's office, talking about everything from her experience shopping for her shoes to being told what bathroom to use at lunch. Mara hadn't realized just how

good Marlena was with makeup until now, seeing her work up close and gaining a new respect for her not capitalizing on her talents, though Adora knew her mom just preferred to teach (and didn't like what she saw from her insider perspective of the industry).

Adora had already been planning on steering clear of her mom's room this afternoon so as to minimize the chances of someone walking in and questioning her, but she had so much to talk about, she almost felt like staying late and walking home when her mom texted that she was headed out. If she had brought a secondary pair of shoes, she probably would have, but the prospect of walking home in these (or her bare feet) was not very appealing to her, and she reluctantly wrapped up their conversation to rejoin her mom en route to the employee parking lot.

When the two meet up by the doors to the parking lot, Adora hugs her mom tightly, still beaming with happiness. The rollercoaster of getting gendered correctly and then misgendered and deadnamed hadn't been fun, but if she had a chance to do it again, she absolutely would. Getting gendered correctly once all those years ago was nice, but getting that validation while going out in style with the help of her mom was a thousand times better.

"Looks like someone's had a good day," her mom remarks as they head outside.

"Oh, it was amazing! Try to guess what happened."

“Nobody recognized you?”

“Yes, but even better, at lunch I got told to use the women’s restroom.”

Marlena’s eyes go wide with surprise, and she momentarily forgets how to unlock the car door as she processes the statement and thinks to who had lunch duty today and double checks to make sure there’s nobody nearby who could have overheard that.

“Did you do it, then?”

“Her tone of voice told me I shouldn’t disobey, so yes, I did.”

“That’s pretty brave,” she remarks. “I probably would’ve been too scared to do that if I was in your position. I’m proud of you, Adora.”

“It was actually a bit nerve wracking at first,” Adora admits. “I hadn’t been planning on doing that since I was intending on holding it until band like usual. It was arguably worse when I got whistled at in first period when I walked into the room, though, since that made everyone look at me and it made me feel really gross.”

As the car rumbles to life, Marlena lets out a sigh. She figured something like this would happen eventually but had been hoping

she could have this discussion later on, kicking the can down the road. But now, it probably wasn't the best idea to keep putting it off.

"Welcome to being a woman, or rather, the really frustrating parts of womanhood. I probably should have talked about this sooner, but I've been avoiding it. But now that you have a taste of it, I think this talk is long overdue."

"About what, that men are pigs?" Adora jokes.

The two chuckle for a bit, and the lightened mood helps her mom continue, "I mean, they certainly can be, but as a woman, you have to be a lot more careful of your surroundings. Especially since you're probably going to take the subway a lot when you move away for college; it's a lot less dangerous than when I was in undergrad and the cars were always covered in graffiti, but I don't want you to become a statistic. Do you know what I'm talking about?"

"I think so, but you can keep going."

"Well," she begins as she puts the car into reverse, "there's a lot I still need to tell you, but this may be the most important. When we get home, I'll show you how to use pepper spray, but until then, there's a lot you need to know about keeping yourself safe."

Chapter End Notes

Something I've noticed about gendered restrooms is that the women's side tends to be better than the men's as a baseline (i.e. most of the time, it's a bit cleaner with less dried pee on the floor, etc.), but when the women's room gets bad, it puts the worst the men's room has to offer to shame. Gender neutral ones tend to be the cleanest (even ones where it's just a line of stalls instead of single occupant), interestingly.

November 5, 2023 update: I have published a new self-contained short story, *Confronting the Past*, that takes place after this chapter but before the next one. I would recommend pausing now, reading *Confronting the Past*, and then proceeding on to the next chapter.

Out

Chapter Notes

> November 5, 2023 update: I have published a new self-contained short story, *Confronting the Past*, that takes place before this chapter. I would recommend pausing now, reading *Confronting the Past*, and then returning to this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

With school finally over, Adora could relax. Her legal name change order had come in the mail a week ago, and she had been over the moon when she pulled it out of the mailbox, practically jumping for joy after opening the clasp on the manilla envelope. When she texted Mara about the good news, her former director had called back almost immediately to congratulate her, despite being on vacation. Changing everything from her bank account to her student ID would take a while, but she had already dealt with everything that didn't require documentation. And with her application for a corrected birth certificate sent off, all she could do was wait since half of the things she had left to update required just that.

That she could even change things this easily was pure luck of the draw. If she had been born in a state like North Carolina, like her friend Perfuma (who was not in the least bit surprised when Adora came out to her, having basically known since they first met in person), getting a name change required two background checks and a bunch of crap she didn't have to worry about. She also didn't need to have SRS to change her birth certificate, though she intended to eventually. Some states, like Tennessee, outright don't allow for updating the sex on a birth certificate, even with a court order. That you could have been in a state for less than a day in your life (like if your mom went into labor while on a vacation) and yet still be held captive by its backwards-ass laws

passed by room-temperature IQ politicians seemed insane. Your birthplace should not be allowed to dictate those terms when you don’t pay them any taxes, she reasoned.

Updating documents was not how she had expected to spend her summer, but it was certainly better than having nothing to do but play video games and work on programming projects while she awaited her move-in date.

Since the summer began, she had also started working out, something she had previously felt uncomfortable doing since it felt like it was a display of masculinity when she was downright uncomfortable with doing things that made her seem more manly. Now, it didn’t bother her since she didn’t have to live as a man, and although she may have been influenced by her love for Wonder Woman, the idea of being a strong woman seemed to fit nicely for her. It was the only thing she regularly got out of the house for, as although she could go out and do whatever since she had a car now, she preferred to stay at home.

Even though her makeup skills had gotten to the point that she could pass fairly reliably, she preferred not to do any of that, or risk having to use the bathroom in a public place without her mom around to reassure her if she had put on makeup (which she basically always did since it was better than getting misgendered, except at the gym since it would run).

With nobody telling her where to go (and therefore, no one to point a finger at if someone thought she didn’t belong), using the restroom had become a much scarier prospect. She knew it was irrational, and once she set foot inside, she had no problem, but

that initial hesitancy still kept her at home or holding it in a lot more than she might have been otherwise.

As the effects of HRT continued to set in, she had begun to feel more dysphoric. Not because there were more things she hated about her body, but because with some things changing in ways she liked, her attention on those that had yet to change was magnified, in addition to those that would not change. In time, things would get better, but it was frustrating having to live through things getting worse first, even if she wasn't going to hit rock bottom like she did the year prior.

The only two people from her school who she ended up coming out to were the two she had previously considered her closest friends, and she did it mainly because she was tired of using a different voice with them when they played Minecraft, which had managed to regain some of its luster now that she wasn't depressed. Neither of them cared as long as she didn't try to come onto them, which she was more than happy with. To them, it was the missing piece in the puzzle. She didn't realize it, but they had been wondering for some time if she was gay because of the way she behaved. For instance, she rarely fist bumped or high fived, instead preferring to give hugs – real ones, too, not bro hugs (which she didn't even realize was a thing, initially assuming it was a satirical term) – and whenever she would open up about something on her mind (which was quite rare), she revealed a lot more of her emotions than was "normal" for a man.

The way she sat had also been making them wonder. During the summer after fifth grade, when visiting relatives in Chicago on her mom's side of the family, they had gone to a diner where the gimmick was that the waitstaff were sassy, and one of the waitresses said that she sat like a girl. It was intended as an

insult, but she didn't realize it, and ordered without even acknowledging it, seeing nothing wrong with crossing her legs the way she did. She had always sat that way (or with her legs pressed together), a fact documented in many a photo album, and never thought twice about it; in fact, this was the first time anyone commented on it (that she knew about). And yet, supposedly it was uncomfortable for men to sit like that due to it getting a bit sweaty. Maybe she had been doing it for so long that her body was used to it, but she never felt any discomfort from it, feeling weird if she sat "like a man."

She had known that her friends were a bit awkward with hugs, but she never could understand why, and certainly didn't think about not doing it since they never said anything. She had also known that men weren't supposed to get emotional and touchy-feely except with their partners but hadn't realized she was violating those social norms. It made her feel bad for her friends, and men more generally, for having to put up a façade to seem normal, to hide their emotions and sit in specific ways lest they be seen as gay, especially since she was finally expressing herself now and realizing just how much she preferred living like this. She was even comfortable answering most of their questions, including ones which strayed into spicier territory, something she could never have imagined doing before.

In the past, Adora had viewed masturbation purely in functional terms: random erections sucked, so she had to prevent them. She didn't enjoy it, partially because it just made her uncomfortable, but also because she never got any pleasure from it. It was something that she had never really mentioned to anyone, not even her mom, because she thought it was just normal. There were a lot of incongruencies in the world, like celebrities who spoke out against the detrimental effects of idealized beauty standards having their photos retouched before being plastered on social media, and she figured that this was just another of

those societal delusions: that masturbation wasn't actually pleasurable.

She had tried some things she had read about online, like edging or abstaining for a while, but it all felt the same to her. As a result, she did it once a week, like clockwork, a routine she didn't really enjoy but which prevented any unwanted tents from being pitched in her pants.

And so, about a month into HRT, when she realized she didn't feel like doing anything (which was a welcome break, especially since doing it took a lot longer due to her antidepressants), she decided to see how long until she started getting more tents. The days stretched into weeks, and soon, she realized they were gone for good.

After a month of not touching herself, her curiosity got the best of her, and despite not needing to get off anymore, she did it anyway. It was surprisingly difficult, taking much more time than it had before, and when she did finish, the smell was different. In the past, getting off always had a very recognizable odor associated with it. By contrast, she barely smelled anything that time. A lot less fluid had come out at the end, so she attributed it to that, but in the months that followed, she found that it had almost completely stopped and had no discernable scent (to her human nose, anyway) – her testicles had basically shut down and begun shrinking.

Not that she was suddenly inclined to get off since she had no real drive at that point, it was purely an intellectual endeavor she engaged in from time to time just to see if anything felt different.

It was a bit more pleasurable than before, but still not very appealing to her.

Eventually, she figured out that masturbation could actually feel pretty good if she used a pillow (and her breasts, which had become an erogenous zone), with orgasms lasting much longer and spreading through her body, but it took a while and she had to do a lot more work than she really cared to get them. But when she did, she always had to pee afterwards, something she had never felt before.

When her sex drive dropped off, so too did her romantic feelings. No longer did she feel attracted to anyone. She had heard this was possible, and that who you were attracted to could change, and she had hoped that she would be a straight woman, or at least bisexual (or asexual).

The idea of being a trans lesbian had a lot of mental baggage associated with it. She had read a fair amount of transphobic nonsense over the years, but it seemed that straight trans women drew less ire than lesbian trans women, who were oftentimes labeled as predators by transphobes (or rather, even bigger predators than straight and asexual trans women). She still had a fair amount of shame over the *male lesbian* feelings from middle school, and even though she had no idea how she would turn out, she did not want to be a lesbian.

Unfortunately, she was onto something back in middle school. For a couple months, she felt zero romantic attraction to anyone, which gave her hope that things would change, but her feelings came back and hit her like a freight train when she was watching a cooking video and immediately began swooning over the

hostess, someone who she had been watching for years but never felt anything for until that point.

Later that same day, she came across a photo of a woman in a suit, and she felt butterflies in her stomach, an interesting departure from feeling attraction in her pants. Her thoughts weren't even sexual in nature, she just wanted to be held by, to cuddle with, to kiss these women so badly, but they were more intense than anything she had felt before and quite difficult to ignore, filling her with worry.

At that point, she had begun thinking "maybe I'm bi," but after seeking out various magazine polls for what men are most attractive, she couldn't figure out what anyone saw in any of them. So, she held out hope that there were more changes coming down the pipe, that she would be "cured" and not have to be a trans lesbian, a part of three marginalized groups, two minorities, and especially hated for it.

She held out for over a month, desperately hoping something would change, but it only seemed to get worse. What finally broke her, however, was when she began crushing on a close friend.

"God, she is cute," Adora muttered as she looked at a picture from their last get-together. It was a Sunday, and they had taken a train down to Manhattan and done a bunch of touristy things before heading back so Adora could get to her band concert. In the picture, taken by Bow at the Transit Museum, the two were sitting in a train car that ran on the BRT's elevated lines, manufactured in 1907. The car itself was quite nice, with intricate wood detailing and much larger windows than on modern subway

cars, but Glimmer stole the spotlight of the image, and she zoomed in to get a better look of her friend's face.

The next image on her phone was of the three of them on the High Line on a bench in front of a massive development that could be seen in the background. She closed her eyes and imagined the two of them kissing, quietly moaning, their bodies pressed together, whispering sweet nothings when their lips parted. Glimmer's hands exploring under her shirt, caressing her chest and whispering "good girl" as she reaches her bra… "*Fuck,*" Adora whimpered as the fantasy progressed being pinned to the bed…at least until Glimmer's hands reached her pants, and the thought of what *could* happen jolted her back to reality, feeling dysphoric and disgusted with herself.

"What am I doing?" she whispered as feelings of guilt took over, guilt over being trans, a lesbian, and attracted to one of her friends, who is cis. "I don't want to be a stereotype," she whimpered as she turned over and buried her face into her pillow.

After some searching, Adora finally figured out why she ever felt any attraction to men, and it came to her when she was reading a document on compulsory heterosexuality. The men she was attracted to were faceless, never having much filled out about them except for personality traits. The ideal man for her was one who didn't exist in reality, as no combination of looks would ever appeal to her, short of her mistaking a guy for a butch woman. When Glimmer would say that a particular person was attractive, they became more interesting to her (and she could recognize when someone was conventionally attractive), but for men, it

always faded quickly when she tried to imagine what it would be like to be with them.

And yet, the idea that to be a woman was to be attracted to men was so deeply ingrained, it had become a coping mechanism that lasted until estrogen eliminated the need for it. She felt crazy for it, as it did seem a little out there (especially since anything that might seem to even remotely support Ray Blanchard's pseudoscientific rubbish on trans women made her feel ashamed of herself), but like when she called herself a "male lesbian," it seemed accurate, and it wasn't until her psychologist reassured her that coping mechanisms oftentimes seem illogical that she felt comfortable enough to tell anyone else.

When she finally told her mom, coming out as a lesbian and admitting her crush, she half expected her mom to be upset that she wasn't straight, but was met with the same love and acceptance as before. In hindsight, if her mom would just accept her immediately for being trans, this should be no different, but her fear got the best of her, especially when she sought out confirmation on /lgbt/.

Admitting she had a crush on her best friend was embarrassing, and she probably would have done nothing if not for her mom encouraging her to be honest since the worst that could happen was not having her feelings reciprocated. And while she agreed that Glimmer was unlikely to ghost her for admitting it, her guilt over being a trans lesbian led her to kick the can down the road for several weeks, alongside guilt for not being honest when she was going to visit soon.

On the eve of the visit, she finally cracked, feeling like she couldn't bring herself to go if she didn't own up to it. She was going to spend the weekend with Glimmer and Bow, and didn't want her emotions to get the best of her and ruin their time together, especially since they were going to start a new D&D campaign, in addition to whatever new board games Bow had come across.

She had met Bow in her last day in the psych ward when he came to visit Glimmer. From the way Glimmer talked about him (and how she always called him several times a day), she knew they were close, and when she saw the two talking to each other, she thought they were dating, and had been surprised to find out they were "just" best friends and neighbors since elementary school. He seemed pretty chill, and when they all met up after Glimmer was discharged, she found out Bow took his name from one of his favorite hobbies, having a range set up in his backyard that was well-used.

Besides D&D and board games, they were most certainly going to be down at the range as well. Adora had gotten decent under Bow's tutelage, good enough that she could definitely get the archery merit badge if she was still in her troop (she had been their first scout to not score enough points for the badge at scout camp), but still nowhere near the skill of her mentor.

Not wanting to try and own up to her feelings in person, she unlocks her phone and goes to call her friend. She stares at the contact, hovering over the phone number, trying to work up the courage to tap on it. Glimmer had already said she was doing nothing productive, so she wasn't going to catch her friend at a bad time, but it's still surprisingly difficult to go through with it.

Eventually, she gives up and flicks back over to reddit to distract herself and calm down a bit. When she feels like she's ready, she tries again, only to hit the same roadblock, and the cycle repeats.

By the time she actually hits the call button, the computer she was sitting in front of has gone to sleep, and the subsequent lack of heat pouring out the back causing her cat, Rose, to leave the room in search of another toasty spot. As it rings, she nervously waits, partially hoping it would go to voicemail. But of course, it's picked up on the fifth ring, just before it would have prompted her to leave a message.

"Adora, about time you called," a tired-sounding Glimmer opens. "I was wondering if you forgot or something. You're lucky you caught me before I silenced this thing for the night."

The voice instantly relaxes Adora, bringing back her daydreams, the feelings she's been dealing with, followed soon after by the shame. At this point, as much as she might want to hang up, she can't unless she wants her friend to get worried about her and repeatedly call her back.

After taking a deep breath, she returns the greeting, and they exchange pleasantries, making small talk for a while. Their conversation meanders from Glimmer's most recent family reunion to what's been in the news, and it continues until she finally feels

comfortable enough to say the real reason she called as a lull in their conversation develops.

"So, I've been dealing with some feelings lately," she begins, already wondering if she's stepped off on the wrong foot. If she was using her parent's old landline, she would have most of the cord wrapped around her finger by now, but alas, the closest thing she has is a hair elastic to occupy her nervous fingers.

"Oh, you found someone you like? Good for you, Adora," her friend replies, sounding excited that she might finally be coming around to dating after saying she felt like it was too much of a minefield before. "Is it a him or a her? Or a them?"

"I mean, well…" she trails off as she accidentally flicks the elastic away and bends down to retrieve it. "Glimmer, I think I'm a lesbian."

"Well good for you on figuring that out," Glimmer says, intending to ask if there was anyone in particular her friend had been thinking about, only to be interrupted before she can say it.

"And I've got a crush on you," Adora blurts out, worried she was about to second-guess herself and not be able to say it if she hesitated.

A silence descends between them as Glimmer processes the words, taken by surprise that her friend had feelings for her. The

silence doesn't last long, but it feels like an ice age to Adora, hating the fate she got stuck with. She didn't go on 4chan very much these days (at least compared to a year ago), but she still had a lot of shame about her sexuality from reading AGP/HSTS nonsense for so long, even though she knew it was a bunch of crap.

Because of her internalized self-hate, the idea of two trans women dating was a lot more acceptable in her mind than a trans woman dating a cis woman. Even though it may be fulfilling a stereotype, at least they were keeping it "to themselves," rather than "imposing" on cis people.

Spending so much time as a man (or rather, pretending to be one), where attraction to women is encouraged and normal (especially in ways that objectify and degrade women), just taking the label "lesbian" when she didn't have to grow up being simultaneously demonized and fetishized for her sexuality, jumping ship when the world was a lot more accepting felt wrong. Like she had spent so long benefiting from the patriarchy that she shouldn't be changing lanes while having done nothing to "earn her stripes."

Logically, of course, she was never living life in easy mode because she was always so depressed, and now her life definitely was harder just for existing as a woman, ignoring the fact that she was both trans and not straight on top of all that. And she hadn't come out because it was convenient, she came out because she was forced out of the closet. Doing voice training, going on HRT, learning how to do makeup, having men tell her to smile more in public (and then calling her "rude" or a "bitch" for not bowing to them), having to be aware of her surroundings

when she took Swift Wind out for walks…she was earning her stripes, all right.

But that knowledge didn't do much to ease her guilt. The feelings of being a predator like TERFs claim, that she was appropriating the idea of being a lesbian (especially since the label "male lesbian" did not feel like a good fit for her anymore), and it made her worried about dating, if that ever happened. She didn't want anyone to view her as a predator and didn't want to be one, she wanted to just exist.

"I'm so sorry, I've been overwhelmed with these feelings. I wish they would go away, and I don't want to put you on the spot, but I thought you should know."

"Don't apologize, Adora," Glimmer tells her reassuringly. "I remember when I came out to myself as bi, I know what you're going through. Or at least, somewhat."

When Glimmer came out to her, she had expressed similar sentiments of worrying about being seen as a predator. Not because of any privilege she may or may not have been born into or because of propaganda she read online, but because of something that happened while in the psych ward.

One of the more interesting characters there was a girl who had been on Dr. Phil and was delusional, always trying to pick fights and generally being an ass to everyone (at one point declaring Adora the Antichrist). She had accused Glimmer of groping her multiple times, and though none of the other patients believed a

word that came out of the drama queen's mouth, the thought that she was attracted to women and could do that, could be a predator (and that others could see her as one), haunted her.

The girl had gotten taken down a peg when she tried to start a fight with one of the psych techs, shouting up a storm before jumping behind the nurses' station and throwing stuff at him. It didn't take long before she got booty juiced, which marked the end of her stay in the unit. Despite basically everyone agreeing she was crazy (or rather, on another level of crazy), and the fact that Glimmer was far from the only one falsely accused of sexual misconduct, the guilt remained over being seen as a predator, and the only way she thought she could avoid it was to not date women, in spite of what others (including Adora) told her. It had certainly kept her in the closet longer than she likely would have been otherwise.

Adora sighs. "Yeah, well, I'm just worried that it'll make things weird, and I didn't want this to come spilling out after I had made that drive up. If you want to cancel this weekend, I won't be upset."

"I don't think it would have, but if you still feel comfortable coming up here, I still want you around. But I should probably tell you now that Bow and I are dating, so I'm sorry to let you down like this, but…yeah."

Of course they finally started dating. And now I'm intruding on their relationship, she thinks, wishing she could retract her words. She didn't want to be an annoyance to others, to seem like she was pushing her way into spaces she didn't belong. Her sense of self-worth had been improving, but things like this tended to set

her back a ways, calling to mind tons of anti-trans crap she had read and watched while trying to repress. It always made her worry that asking for anything was just her being rude to others, and she still tended to put her own wants second to others as a result.

"You still there?" Glimmer asks, breaking the silence.

"Yeah, I'm here. I'm just surprised it took you this long. And I wouldn't have bothered if I knew, I don't want to intrude on you two."

"You're not intruding on anything, Adora," she asserts, having a good idea of what would be going through her friend's head from all the venting she's done in the past. "And I think a big part of Bow taking this long was he didn't feel very sure of himself before starting T. Like how you talked about how attractions can change, and he was worried about that happening." Her tone gets lighter as she continues, "Speaking of, he's got his first facial hairs now. And his voice has dropped more since last time, if you can believe it."

The reassurance from her friend helps, and Adora cracks a smile. "Well, good for him. It's nice to see someone actually enjoys that stuff. I have my next appointment to laser it all off on Tuesday."

"I still can't believe you do that. I went to one appointment for my legs and couldn't handle it."

Adora rolls her eyes at her friend's low pain tolerance. She had done two rounds so far at a place recommended by one of Mara's friends for being trans-friendly, and even though she couldn't wear makeup since she was getting her face done (along with her chest and legs), they had only misgendered her the first time she walked in. It certainly wasn't painless, but she could put up with it, and talking with the person who operated the machine easily took her mind off of it.

Already, she could shave in the morning and not have to worry about any stubble showing through makeup until late evening, which allowed her to go out in girlmode for longer without worry. One of her greatest fears had been getting outed by her facial hair poking through after just a few hours (and either having to strip off her makeup and boymode or risk getting harassed), but now, she could spend the day running errands with her mom or exploring Manhattan with her friends.

Having to shave twice a day to deal with her dysphoria had become a chore, too. Not just because it took time for the hot water to arrive at the upstairs bathroom, but also because her skin was much softer now, and she had to be more careful when shaving. Previously, she could wield her razor like an idiot, and any knicks would scab over in minutes, but now, she had to be more careful since it took much longer for her skin to heal. In fact, she bruised and got cut *really* easily. Carrying a computer? Bruise and maybe a cut. Hit the coffee table with your knee? Bruise. Tough time opening a jar? Bruise. Cat climbs onto your bare legs with claws out? Bruises and cuts galore.

It was ridiculous at times, but as her mom would say, welcome to being a woman. Eventually, Bow would experience the opposite: skin becoming more abrasive, bruising much less, and healing

quicker. Getting to know Bow had been an experience for her. She knew trans men existed but hadn't made the connection that anyone would actually enjoy the effects of testosterone until meeting him; that hating your voice dropping, facial hair, etc. is not what men do.

Of course, the way men generally interacted with each other was far more surface level than women, but that was due to cultural standards rather than any innate characteristics of testosterone or estrogen. But that anyone could like the physical attributes typically associated with men and masculinity was a bit of a revelation to her, realizing just how much of a man she never was.

"You just need to grow a pair," Adora sarcastically replies.

"Pretty sure I already have one, you're saying I need a second in my pants?" her friend shoots back.

The two chuckle. Adora didn't mind joking about this kind of stuff with them since she knew they weren't judging her, and she didn't have to explain the jokes and ruin their comedic value. She wished she had more friends like them, or that the Best Friend Squad wasn't separated by (at best) an hour and a half of driving. Joking about this stuff over the phone always left the potential for someone to overhear her, so she preferred to reserve that style of humor for when they were together and knew they were alone.

"Yeah, that sounds about right. Those succulent clippings I left you should do the job."

Glimmer rolls her eyes, though Adora certainly can't see it. "Didn't realize that was the optimal growing environment," she sarcastically remarks while stifling a yawn. "Anyway, I need to get to sleep before I nod off on you. You still up for visiting?"

"Yeah, I think I am."

"Good, let me know when you head out tomorrow."

Before Adora can say anything, the call ends like all of Glimmer's calls do: without the chance to say goodbye. She had ribbed her friend for it before, and the next few times it didn't happen, but old habits die hard, and it didn't take long to revert to the abrupt hanging up.

She gets up from her chair and stretches. It's close to midnight, and she needs to get to sleep now unless she wants to arrive in the middle of lunch. Part of her still worried about what Bow might say when Glimmer inevitably tells him about their conversation, but that was a problem for future Adora; right now, she needed to rest, especially after today's leg day workout.

Chapter End Notes

The Transgender Pride Flag

I am a symbol of pride.
Of daring to be who I truly am,
despite the risks I face in doing so.

I embody both an uncomfortable past and hope for the future.
Crossing my stripes is a long and difficult task but
will lead to a happiness not possible remaining in place.

And in doing so, learning from others and
blazing my own path as I embrace my true colors,
I help to inspire those who dream of making their own journey towards inner peace.

My wrinkles and creases will fade in time, as
I fully realize myself and who I truly want to be.

Thanks for reading this far. I wrote this to have more realistic trans representation, especially pre-coming out (to everyone else), which is something that is sorely overlooked in trans* fics in my opinion. And to touch on some of the problems with living in the closet while being on HRT (often referred to as “boymoding”). And what it’s like having someone who supports you, how much of a difference it makes, especially when you didn’t come out on your own terms.

Also, that bit about Adora not being able to get the archery merit badge? That was me, the worst archer in my troop. 😳

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!